Relay

A guide for you and the people you trust — what it does, how each part works, and why it is built the way it is.

Relay holds the things your family would need if you could not be reached — the account that everything else recovers through, the bank, the policy number, the instruction that only lives in your head — and hands them to specific people, only when specific people agree something has actually happened.

It is not a password manager, and it is not a will. A password manager assumes you are there to open it. A will assumes you are not coming back. Relay is for the long middle: the surgery, the accident, the three weeks in hospital, the trip where nobody could reach you. **Everything it does is reversible by you, right up until you choose something that is not.**

The one idea worth understanding

Nothing opens because a computer decided it should. Something opens because *people you named in advance* said it was real. Relay's job is to make that agreement possible at three in the morning, between people who may never have met, without any of them having to trust a stranger's email.

Three promises the design keeps, everywhere, without exception.

- **Relay never sends you a link that signs you in.** Not one. So any message claiming to be us that asks you to click one is, categorically, not us. This is why you type short codes instead of clicking links — it is mildly less convenient and it removes an entire class of attack on your family.
- **What is inside your vault never leaves your browser unencrypted.** Relay cannot read your items. Neither can anyone who steals the database.
- **Everything that happens is written to a record that cannot be edited or deleted** — including by us. That is what makes the summary you read afterwards trustworthy rather than merely reassuring.

What is in this guide

PART 1

Setting it up

Done once, in this order. Most people finish in under an hour, and the order matters more than the speed — each step assumes the one before it.

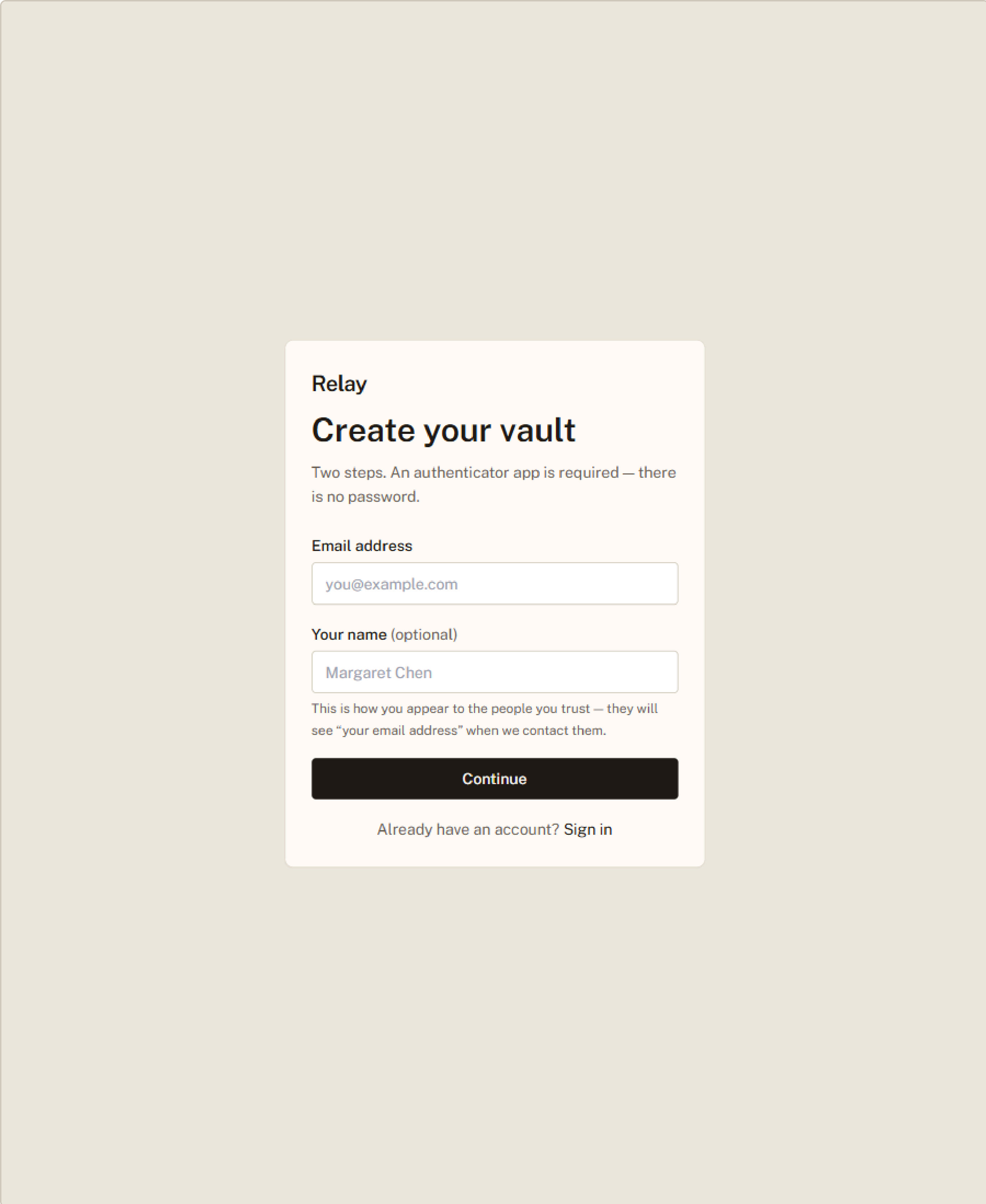
1.0 — Getting in, and the one thing to keep

You · once, at the start

> **Why there is no password.** A password is a thing you can be persuaded to type into a convincing page. Relay uses an authenticator app instead, so there is nothing an imitation of us could ask you for that would work.

Two steps and no password. Set **your name** while you are there — it is how you appear to everybody you name, and the signup page shows you what they would otherwise see.

Keep the recovery codes. They are shown once, they are the only way back if you lose the phone with your authenticator on it, and nobody — including us — can reissue them for you afterwards.



Creating a vault. The name field shows the consequence of leaving it blank, at the one moment it can still be avoided.

1.1 — Put in what actually matters

You · the Vault screen

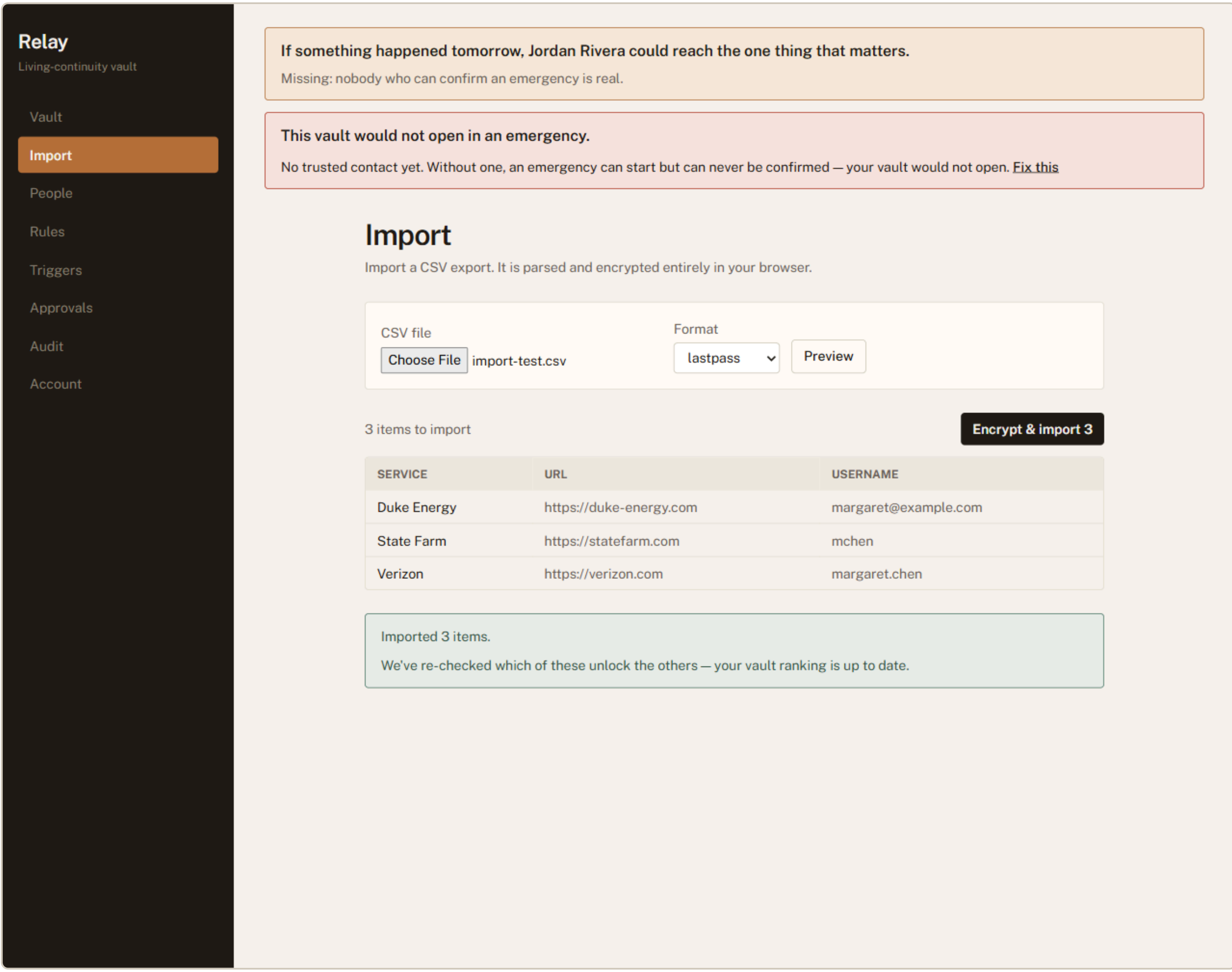
> **Why this exists.** The instinct is to put in everything. That is the wrong instinct, and it is the main reason plans like this fail: a list of ninety accounts is a list nobody can act on. Your family needs the four or five things that

> unlock the rest.

How it works. Add an item and Relay encrypts it *in your browser* before it is sent anywhere. It then scores each item for consequence and sorts the list with the most consequential first — the account that other accounts recover through outranks the one with the biggest balance, because losing the recovery path means losing everything downstream.

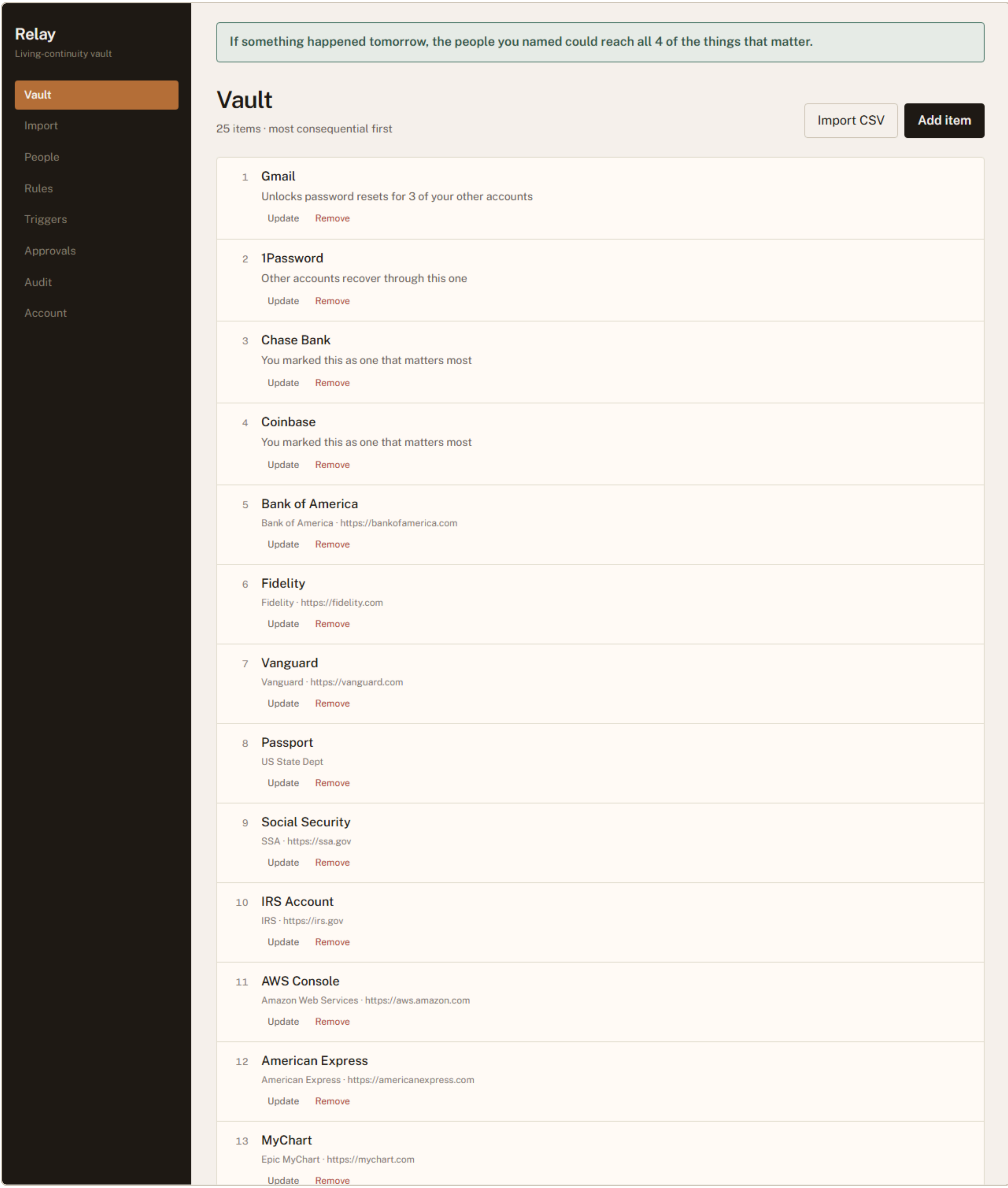
- Items are ordered by what would be hardest to live without, not by when you added them.
- The line under each item tells you *why* it is ranked where it is.
- **Import CSV** takes an export from a password manager, which is how most people should start — it is parsed and encrypted in your browser, and you see exactly what is about to be added before anything is written. Rows you already have are skipped rather than duplicated, and the count of skips is reported: a silent skip would have you believe credentials went missing.

> **The free plan holds ten items and four people.** That is deliberately enough to reach the point of the product — the four or five things that unlock the rest, and the handful of people who would step in — rather than a trial that expires. A file larger than the remaining room is refused whole rather than trimmed to fit, because a vault that quietly stopped halfway through your export is exactly the false sense of completeness this is meant to prevent.



The preview shows the service, the address and the username — and **no passwords**. It is the one screen where somebody looking over your shoulder would otherwise see the whole file at once.

The banner across the top is the single most useful thing on the screen. It answers one question — *if something happened tomorrow, would this work?* — and it is honest about the answer.



The vault, most consequential first. The prompt at the bottom points at the next thing that would actually help — a vault nobody can open is a vault that does nothing.

1.2 — Name the people

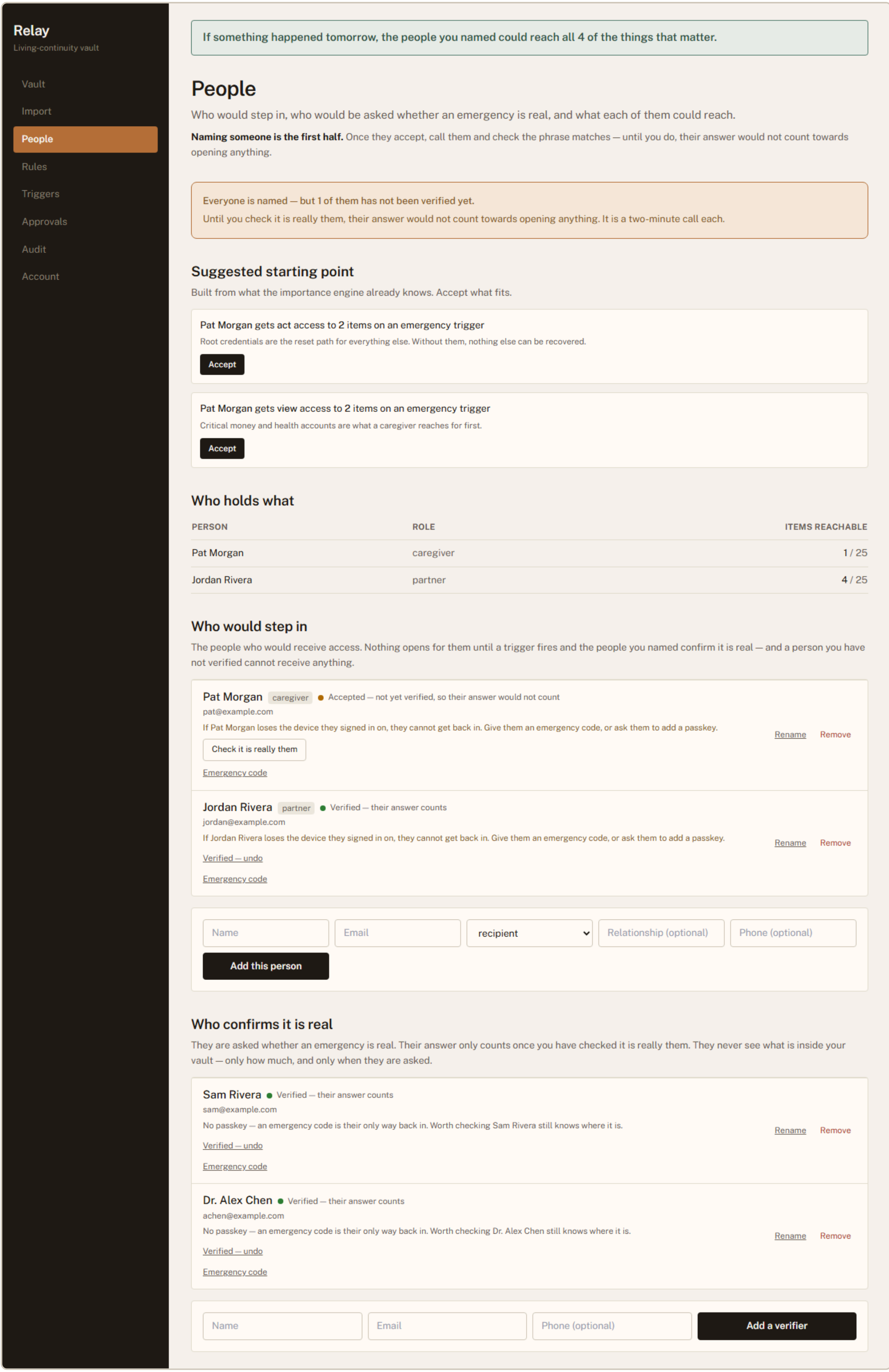
You · the People screen

> **Why this exists.** Two different jobs get confused constantly, and confusing them is how a plan ends up doing nothing. **Some people receive access. Other people are asked whether the emergency is real.** They can be the same person, but the roles are separate, and a plan needs both.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO	WHAT THEY SEE
Who would step in (recipients)	Receive access to the items you assign them, and only after a release opens.	Before a release: that they are standing by, for whom, and how much is set aside — counts and categories only, never titles.
Who confirms it is real (verifiers)	Answer one question — is this genuine? — and nothing else. They never receive access.	At the moment they are asked: how much is at stake and what kind of thing it is. Never a title, never a contents.

Naming someone is only the first half. Once they accept, Relay derives a short phrase from their account. You call them — an actual call — and check the phrase they read out matches the one on your screen. That call is what turns "someone with this email address accepted" into "this is my sister". Until you make it, **their answer does not count towards opening anything.**

> **Why a phone call, in a product that is otherwise entirely software.** Every purely-digital way of proving identity here reduces to trusting an email inbox, and an inbox is the thing most likely to be compromised in exactly the scenario this product exists for. Two minutes on the phone is stronger than anything we could build, and it costs you one call per person, once.



The People screen: the coverage table, then the two rosters. Each person's line says what is still missing rather than merely what state they are in.

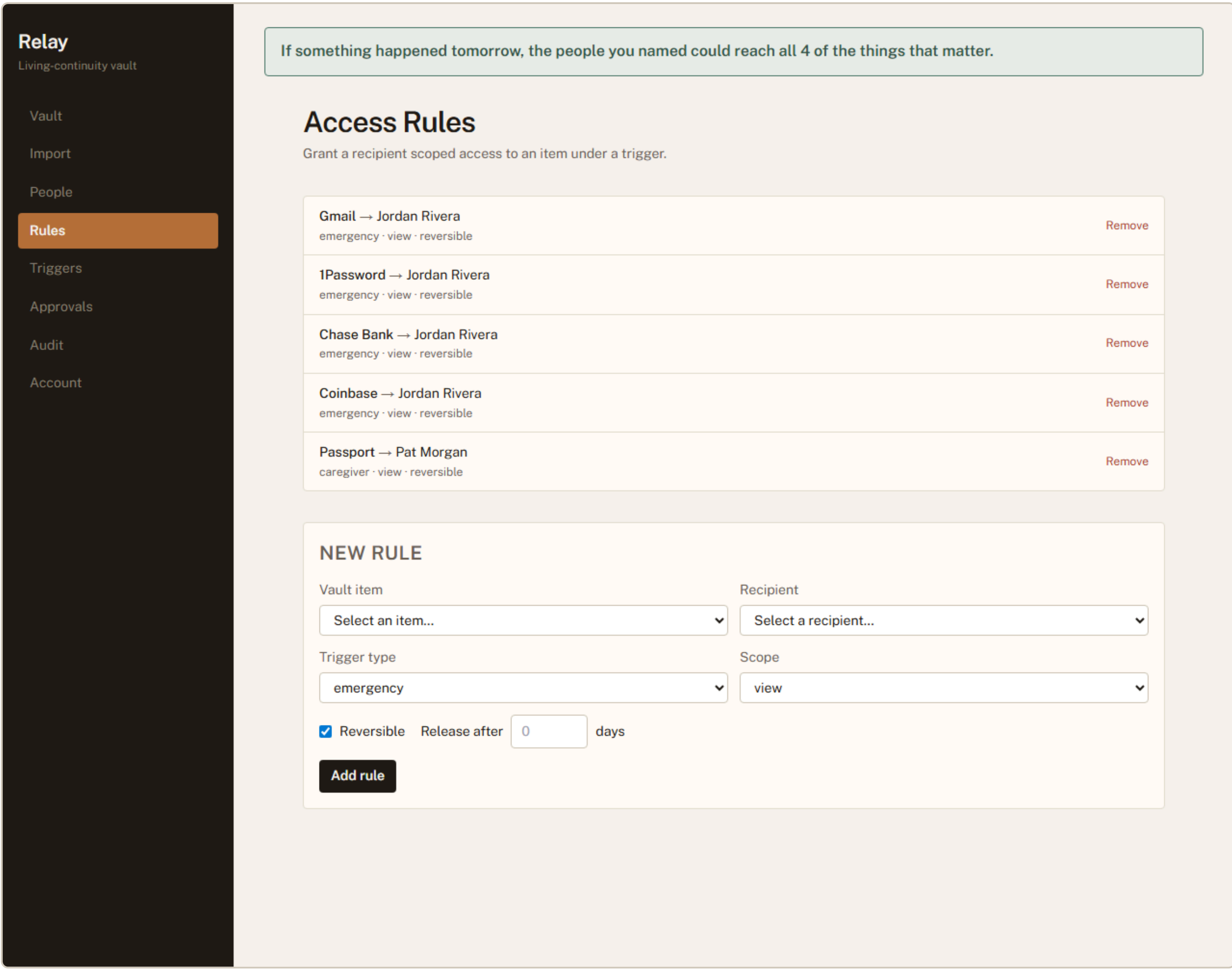
1.3 — Decide who can reach what

> **Why this exists.** "My family gets everything" is not a plan, it is an abdication. The person helping with your mother's care needs the health portal and the utility account; they do not need your solicitor's file. Scoping access is what makes it safe to name more than one person.

A rule is one sentence: *this item → this person*, under *this kind of emergency*, to *view* or to *act*. You can build them by hand, or accept the suggestions Relay drafts from what it already knows about your items — most people accept the draft and edit two lines.

- **View** means read it. **Act** means use it — sign in, pay the bill, call the bank.
- **Reversible** means access closes again when you check back in. This is the default and it is the whole reason an emergency release is not frightening.
- **Release after N days** holds a rule back. The urgent things open the moment a release happens; the rest wait, and only open if you are *still* unreachable that many days later. The person it is for sees the item on their list from the start, marked with the date it opens, so they know something is coming rather than concluding the plan is broken.

Every rule you can write today is reversible. The four situations you can choose between — an emergency, a trip, a caregiving arrangement, something at work — all close again when you check back in. The permanent handover is built, and it is deliberately not offered while it waits on a written legal opinion; when it does arrive it will not let you mark it reversible, because a handover that can be taken back is not a handover.



Existing rules read as sentences. The trigger a rule is written for is created the moment you write the rule — which is why an unused trigger never appears and can never fire.

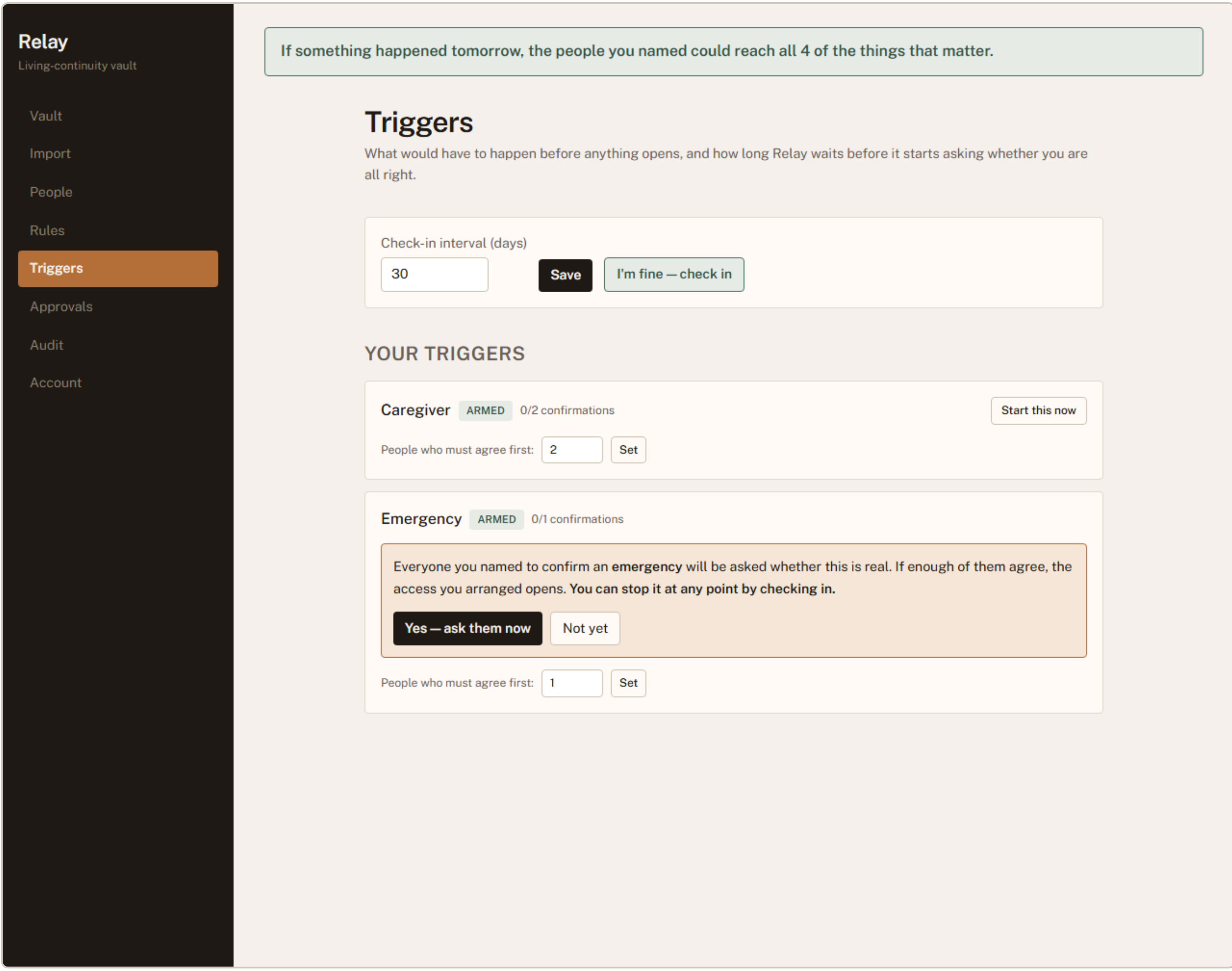
1.4 — Set the conditions

You · the Triggers screen

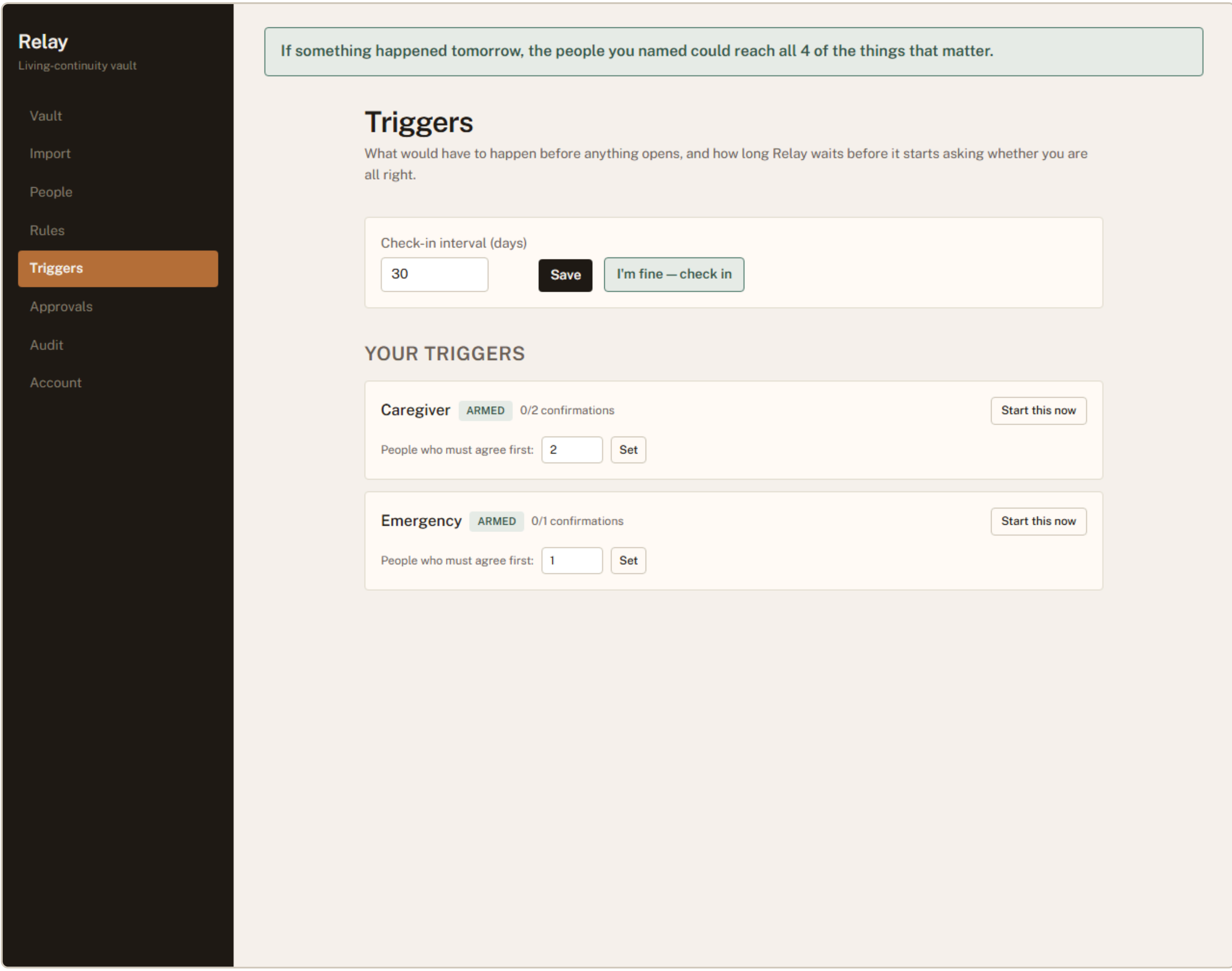
> **Why this exists.** The dangerous failure is not "it opened too late". It is "it opened when nothing was wrong". Every default here leans towards staying shut.

Two settings, and one button you will hopefully never press.

- **Check-in interval.** How long Relay waits before it starts asking whether you are all right. Thirty days suits most people. Any deliberate action in the product counts as checking in, so ordinary use keeps it quiet — you are not being asked to remember a chore.
- **People who must agree first.** How many of your verifiers have to say yes before anything opens. One is enough for a small circle. Two is meaningfully harder to fake and is worth it once you have three or more verified people.
- **Start this now** fires that trigger yourself — the “I know I am about to be unreachable” button. It still needs your verifiers to confirm; it does not skip anyone. It asks you to confirm first, and tells you exactly what is about to happen rather than asking whether you are sure.



Starting one deliberately. It names the consequence, and says plainly that checking in stops it — because “are you sure?” is a question nobody reads.



A trigger sits **ARMED** and does nothing until either you initiate it or you stop checking in. Armed is the safe state, and every failure inside Relay resolves back to it.

1.5 — Someone to help you set it up

You · the Approvals screen

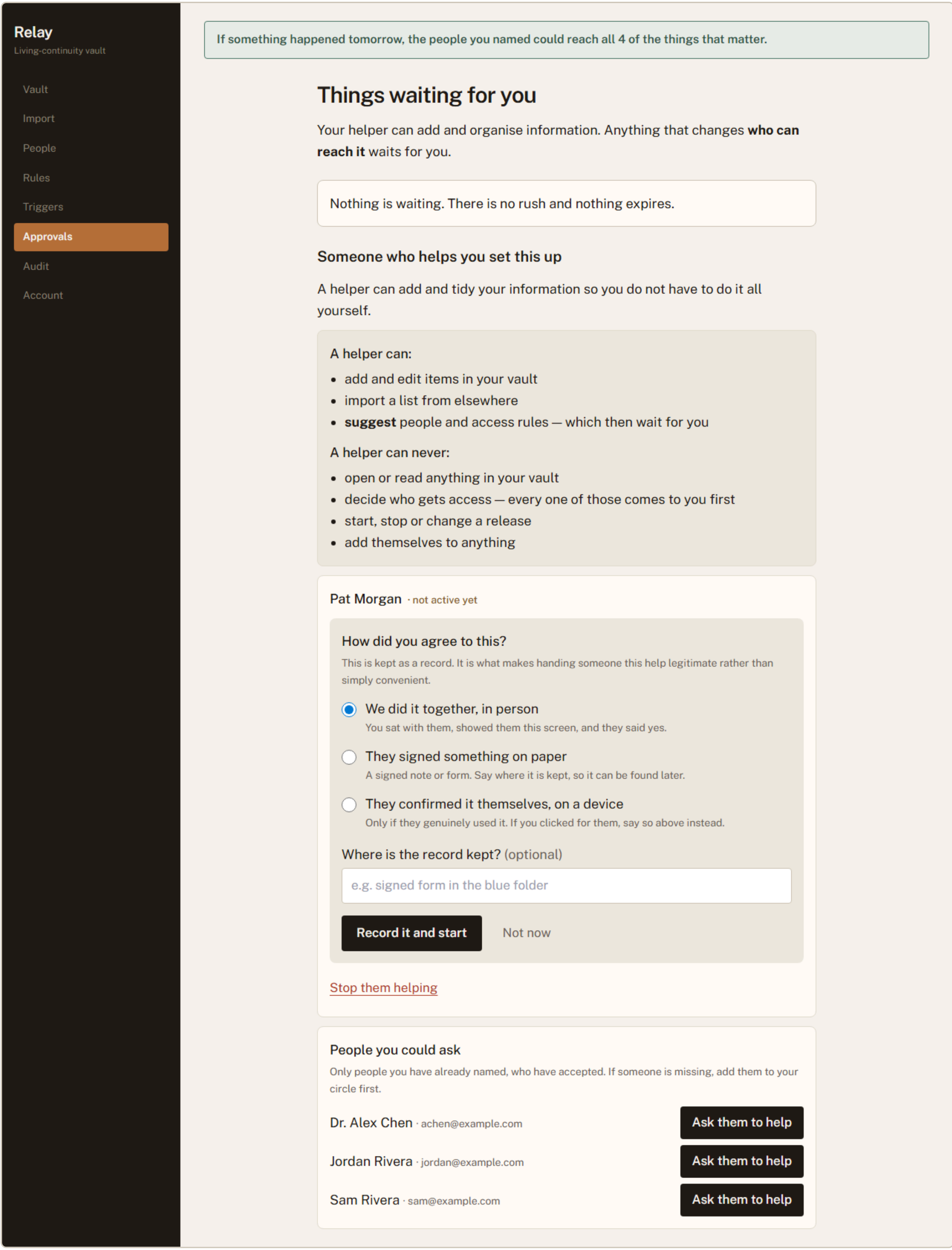
> **Why this exists.** The person who most needs this is often the least likely to do the typing — and the adult child who bought it is usually sitting next to them anyway. The alternative, in practice, is that they sign in as you, which destroys every guarantee in this document at once.

A helper can add and tidy your information. A helper can **never** open anything, decide who gets access, or touch a release — anything that changes who can reach what comes to you as a question. You choose them from people you have already named who have accepted, so this is always an *elevation* of somebody known rather than an introduction of somebody new.

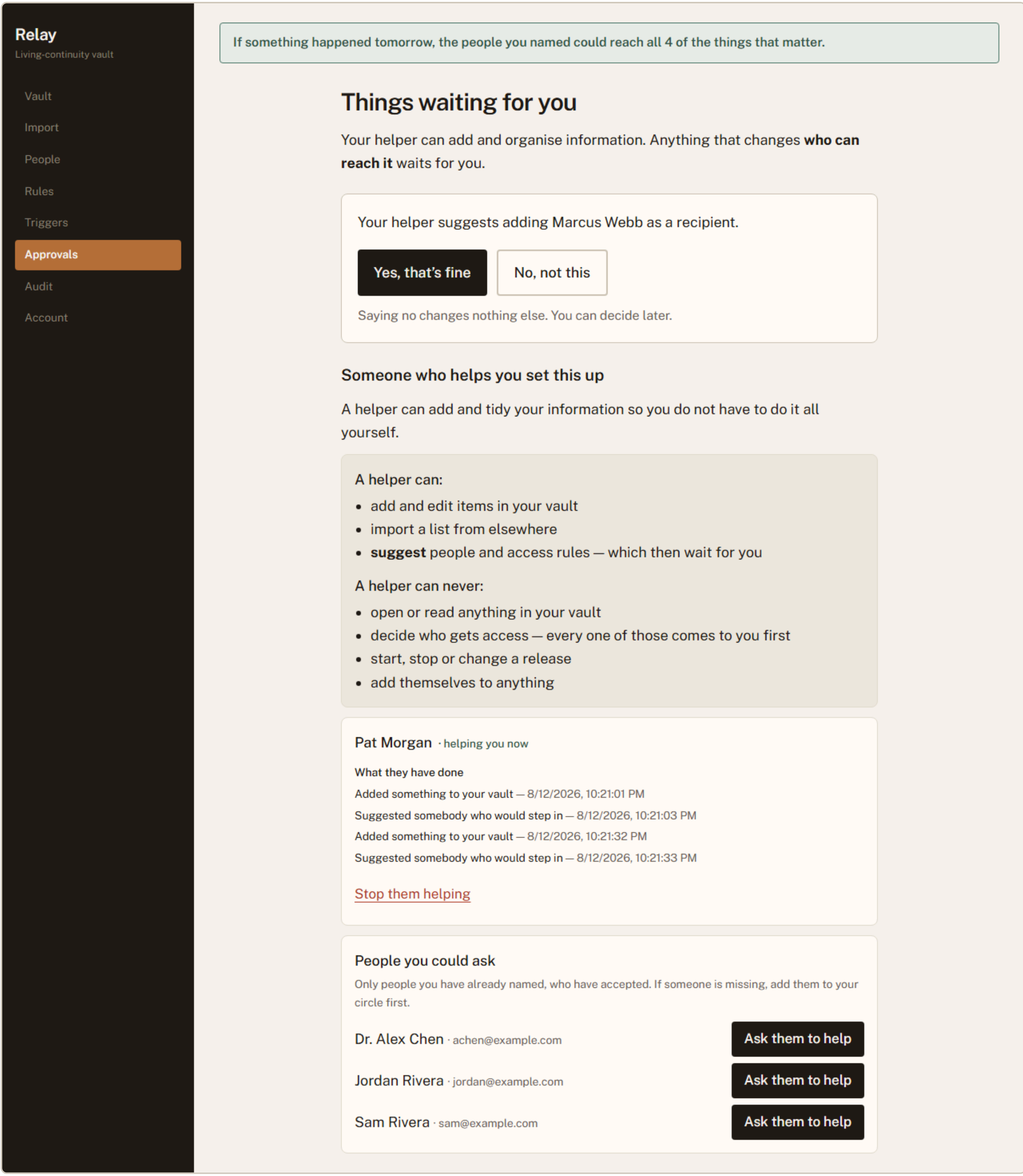
It does nothing until you record how you agreed to it — together in person, on paper, or confirmed by them on a device. That record is not a formality: it is what makes handing somebody this help legitimate rather than merely convenient, and it is why “in person” and “on paper” are offered as equals rather than buried under a link.

Once it is recorded, they see it on their own screen and can start. Anything they suggest about *people* arrives in your **Approvals** queue as a question, including — especially — if they suggest themselves. Approving runs it through exactly the checks it would face if you had typed it yourself.

You can also see **what they have actually done** — each thing they added, each person they suggested — on the same screen as the button that stops them helping. Everything they do is also in your record, under their name.



The record that starts it. Nothing works until this is filled in, and the option that invites a convenient lie — “they confirmed it themselves” — is worded to discourage one.



Active, with a suggestion waiting. What a helper can and can never do is stated before the button rather than after it; **what they have done** sits directly above the control that stops them, so the evidence is beside the decision it informs rather than a screen away.

PART 2

Living with it

This is the part that lasts for years, and the part most products get wrong by demanding attention they have not earned.

2.1 — Knowing whether it would actually work

You · the banner on every screen

> **Why this exists.** The worst outcome for a product like this is not failing. It is *appearing to work* for four years and then failing on the one day it is needed. So the banner is deliberately hard to satisfy and deliberately specific about what is missing.

It goes green when the plan could actually run — not when you have filled in every field. And when it is not green it names **the single fastest thing you could do next**, rather than listing everything imperfect about your setup.

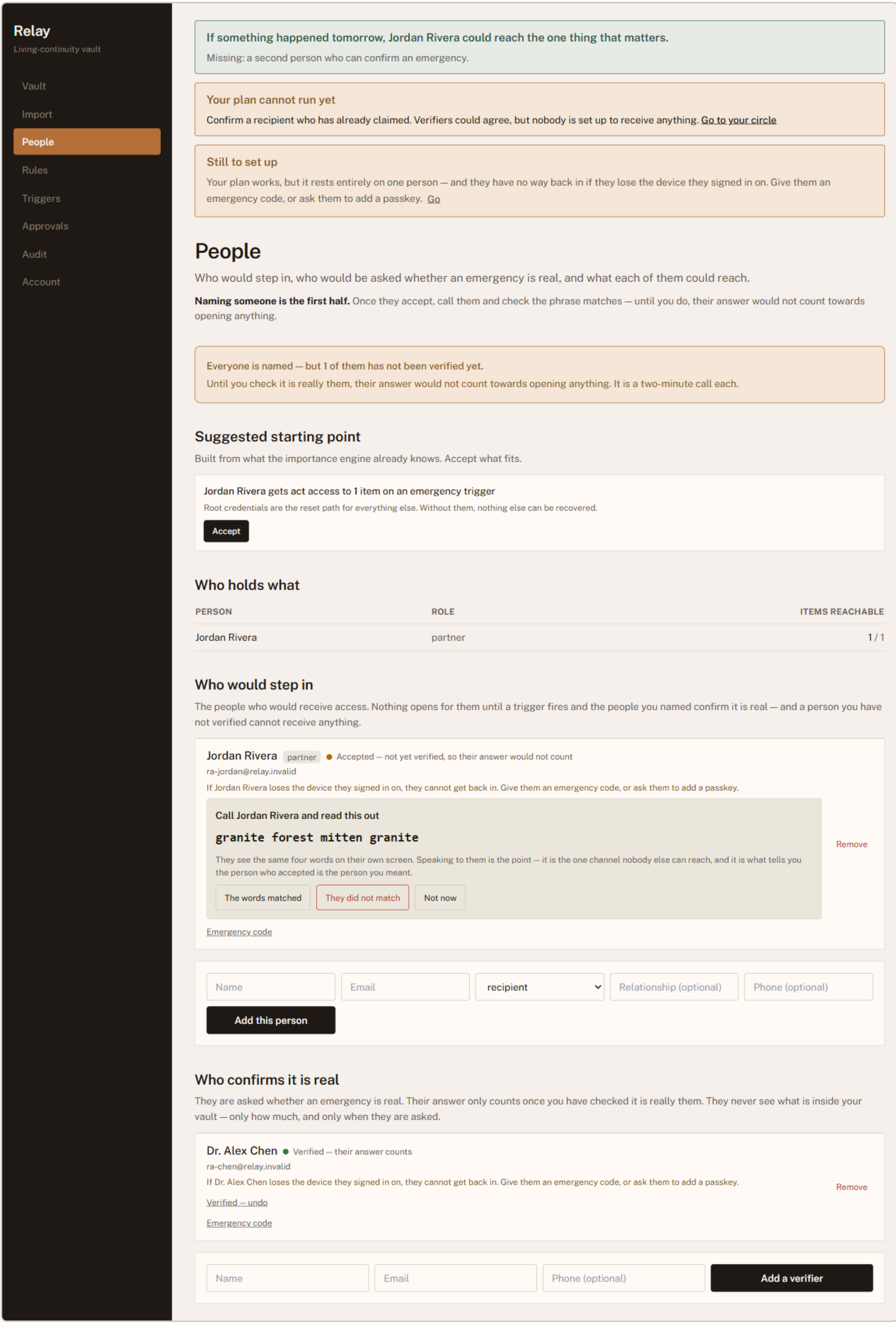
WHAT IT SAYS	WHAT IT MEANS
Green	Enough verified people, enough coverage. If something happened tomorrow, this works.
Nobody could confirm	You have named verifiers but not verified them, so nothing can open. This is the most common state for a new plan and the phone call fixes it.
Your plan rests on one person	It works, but every verified person is needed and at least one of them has no way back in if they lose their phone. Not urgent; worth an afternoon.

2.2 — Making the call that makes it work

You · two minutes per person, once

Naming somebody is half of it. When they accept, four words appear on your screen and the same four on theirs. Ring them, **read yours out**, and ask whether theirs match. If they do, mark them verified — and only from that moment does their answer count towards opening anything.

If the words do **not** match, stop. It means somebody else opened the invitation you sent. The same panel removes them, cancels the code, and puts them back to not-yet-invited so you can try again on a channel you trust.



Your side of the call. It is two minutes, it is not optional, and it is the only thing that can tell the person you meant from somebody who intercepted the invitation.

2.3 — Keeping it current

> **Why this is the part that actually decides whether it works.** Setting this up takes an hour once. Keeping it true takes a few minutes a year, and it is the difference between a plan and a museum: a password rotated in 2027 and never updated here is an item your family will open, read, and find does not work — at the worst possible moment, with no way to tell that from a plan that was never any good.

Update a value. Update beside an item lets you correct both what it is called and what it holds — the rotated password, the corrected account number — encrypted in your browser exactly as the first one was. Relay cannot show you the old value, because it cannot read it, so this replaces rather than edits it. Rules can be removed and rewritten. None of it needs anybody's permission and none of it is a support request.

What removal takes with it. This is the part worth knowing before you click rather than after, because it is not obvious:

- Removing an **item** also deletes every rule pointing at it. Nobody is left with a grant to something that no longer exists.
- Removing a **person** also deletes every rule and every draft policy written for them. If they were the only one who could reach your bank, nobody can now — the banner will say so immediately.
- Removing somebody is **permanent**, so the screen asks first and tells you how many things go with them. Re-adding the same person later creates a new place that has to be accepted and verified again from scratch.

Names can be corrected, and one of them matters more than it looks. Rename beside a person fixes a spelling without disturbing anything else — they stay verified, they keep their place, and no new code or phone call is needed. It is worth doing, because their name is not decoration: it is what your people read in the message that matters ("Margaret Chen has asked you to confirm an emergency"), on the one day it is hardest to check whether a message is genuine.

An email address is different. Changing one is not offered, because a person who has already accepted stays bound to the account they accepted with — so a new address would not move them. If you sent an invitation to the wrong address, remove them and invite again.

Removing is not the same as somebody stepping down. When *you* remove them, they are gone and their rules go too. When *they* step down, their place survives, empty and red, waiting for you to decide — see 5.7. The difference exists so that nobody can quietly shrink your circle, including you in a hurry.

2.4 — Checking in

You · anywhere

Signing in and *changing* something is a check-in. Adding an item, editing one, writing a rule, naming somebody, answering a helper's suggestion, setting your name — all of it resets the clock, so ordinary use keeps things quiet and you are not being asked to remember a chore.

Reading is not a check-in, and that is deliberate. A phone left signed in on a hospital bedside table will load pages for days without anybody touching it. If that counted, the one situation this product exists for would be the situation in which it quietly did nothing.

There is also an explicit **I'm fine — check in** button on the Triggers screen for when you want to be certain rather than incidental. A check-in does three things at once: it resets the clock, it reverses a release that is in progress, and it closes access that has already opened. One action, all of it.

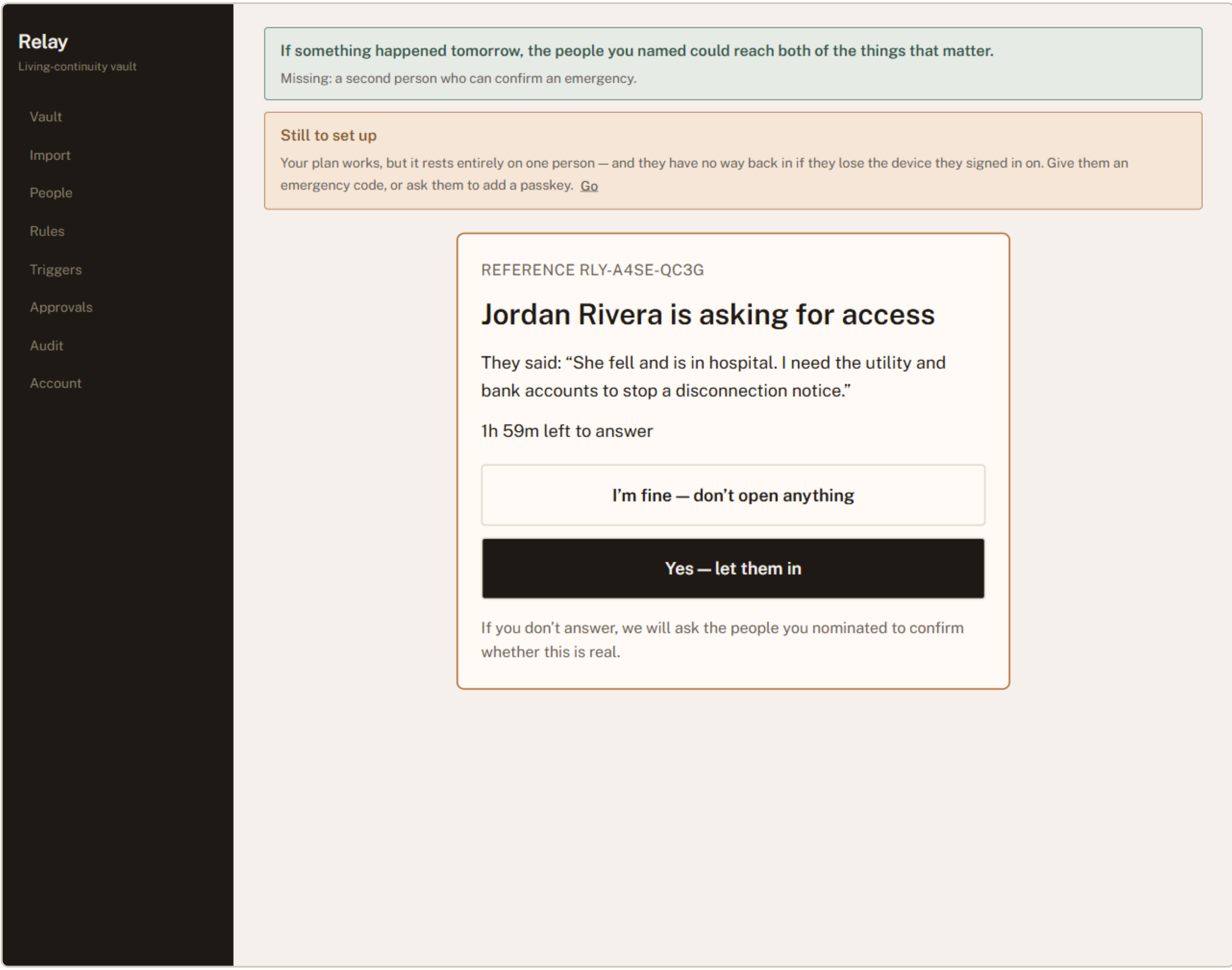
2.5 — Somebody asks, and you are fine

You · the Challenge screen

> **Why you are asked first.** If a person you named needs something before any trigger has fired, the polite version of that is a question to you — not a mechanism that routes around you.

You see who asked, in their own words, and how long you have to answer. Say you are fine and nothing opens. If you cannot answer in time, the people you chose to confirm an emergency are asked instead — which is the point: it does not depend on you being reachable.

Everyone else you named is told a request was made, whatever you decide. That is deliberate, and it is what makes a quiet attempt on your accounts impossible.



The question, with a countdown and both answers.

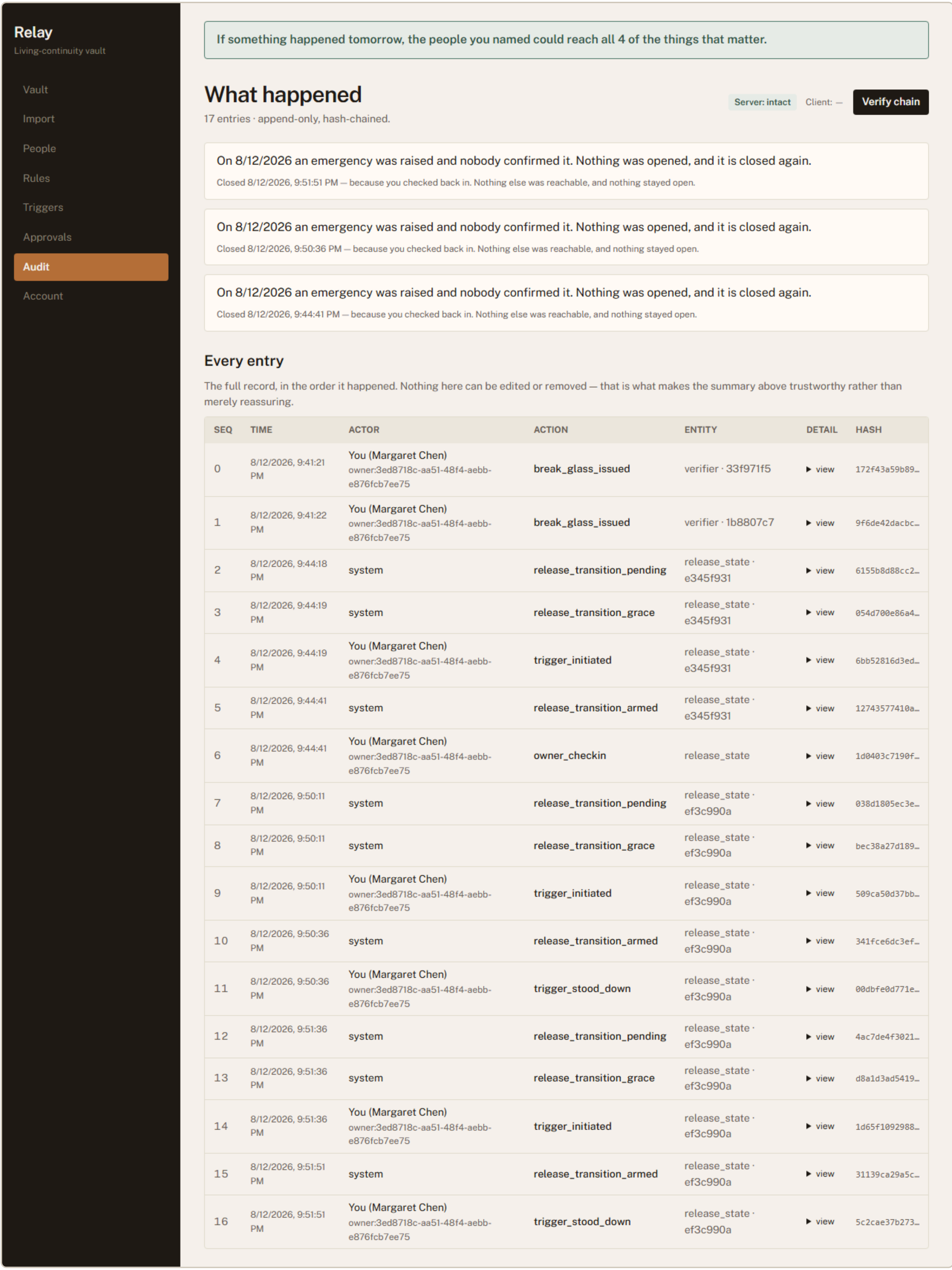
2.6 — Reading what happened

You · the Audit screen

> **Why this exists.** Coming home and finding that people could see your accounts is unsettling even when everything worked exactly as designed. The record is what converts that from a vague unease into something you can actually check.

The top of the screen is the story in sentences: what was raised, who confirmed it, what was opened, when it closed, and why. Beneath it is every entry in order, hash-chained so that changing any one of them breaks the chain visibly. **Verify chain** re-computes it in front of you.

It distinguishes two things that are easy to conflate: somebody *seeing* what was set aside for them, and somebody *opening* it. If your partner signed in and looked at the list without revealing anything, the record says exactly that rather than telling you nothing happened.



Relay
Living-continuity vault

- Vault
- Import
- People
- Rules
- Triggers
- Approvals
- Audit
- Account

If something happened tomorrow, the people you named could reach all 4 of the things that matter.

What happened

Server: intact · Client: — · Verify chain

17 entries · append-only, hash-chained.

On 8/12/2026 an emergency was raised and nobody confirmed it. Nothing was opened, and it is closed again.
Closed 8/12/2026, 9:51:51 PM — because you checked back in. Nothing else was reachable, and nothing stayed open.

On 8/12/2026 an emergency was raised and nobody confirmed it. Nothing was opened, and it is closed again.
Closed 8/12/2026, 9:50:36 PM — because you checked back in. Nothing else was reachable, and nothing stayed open.

On 8/12/2026 an emergency was raised and nobody confirmed it. Nothing was opened, and it is closed again.
Closed 8/12/2026, 9:44:41 PM — because you checked back in. Nothing else was reachable, and nothing stayed open.

Every entry

The full record, in the order it happened. Nothing here can be edited or removed — that is what makes the summary above trustworthy rather than merely reassuring.

SEQ	TIME	ACTOR	ACTION	ENTITY	DETAIL	HASH
0	8/12/2026, 9:41:21 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	break_glass_issued	verifier · 33f971f5	▸ view	172f43a59b89…
1	8/12/2026, 9:41:22 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	break_glass_issued	verifier · 1b8807c7	▸ view	9f6de42dacbc…
2	8/12/2026, 9:44:18 PM	system	release_transition_pending	release_state · e345f931	▸ view	6155b8d88cc2…
3	8/12/2026, 9:44:19 PM	system	release_transition_grace	release_state · e345f931	▸ view	054d700e86a4…
4	8/12/2026, 9:44:19 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	trigger_initiated	release_state · e345f931	▸ view	6bb52816d3ed…
5	8/12/2026, 9:44:41 PM	system	release_transition_armed	release_state · e345f931	▸ view	12743577410a…
6	8/12/2026, 9:44:41 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	owner_checkin	release_state	▸ view	1d0403c7190f…
7	8/12/2026, 9:50:11 PM	system	release_transition_pending	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	038d1805ec3e…
8	8/12/2026, 9:50:11 PM	system	release_transition_grace	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	bec38a27d189…
9	8/12/2026, 9:50:11 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	trigger_initiated	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	509ca50d37bb…
10	8/12/2026, 9:50:36 PM	system	release_transition_armed	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	341fce6dc3ef…
11	8/12/2026, 9:50:36 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	trigger_stood_down	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	00dbfe0d771e…
12	8/12/2026, 9:51:36 PM	system	release_transition_pending	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	4ac7de4f3021…
13	8/12/2026, 9:51:36 PM	system	release_transition_grace	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	d8a1d3ad5419…
14	8/12/2026, 9:51:36 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	trigger_initiated	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	1d65f1092988…
15	8/12/2026, 9:51:51 PM	system	release_transition_armed	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	31139ca29a5c…
16	8/12/2026, 9:51:51 PM	You (Margaret Chen) owner:3ed8718c-aa51-48f4-aebb-e876fcb7ee75	trigger_stood_down	release_state · ef3c990a	▸ view	5c2cae37b273…

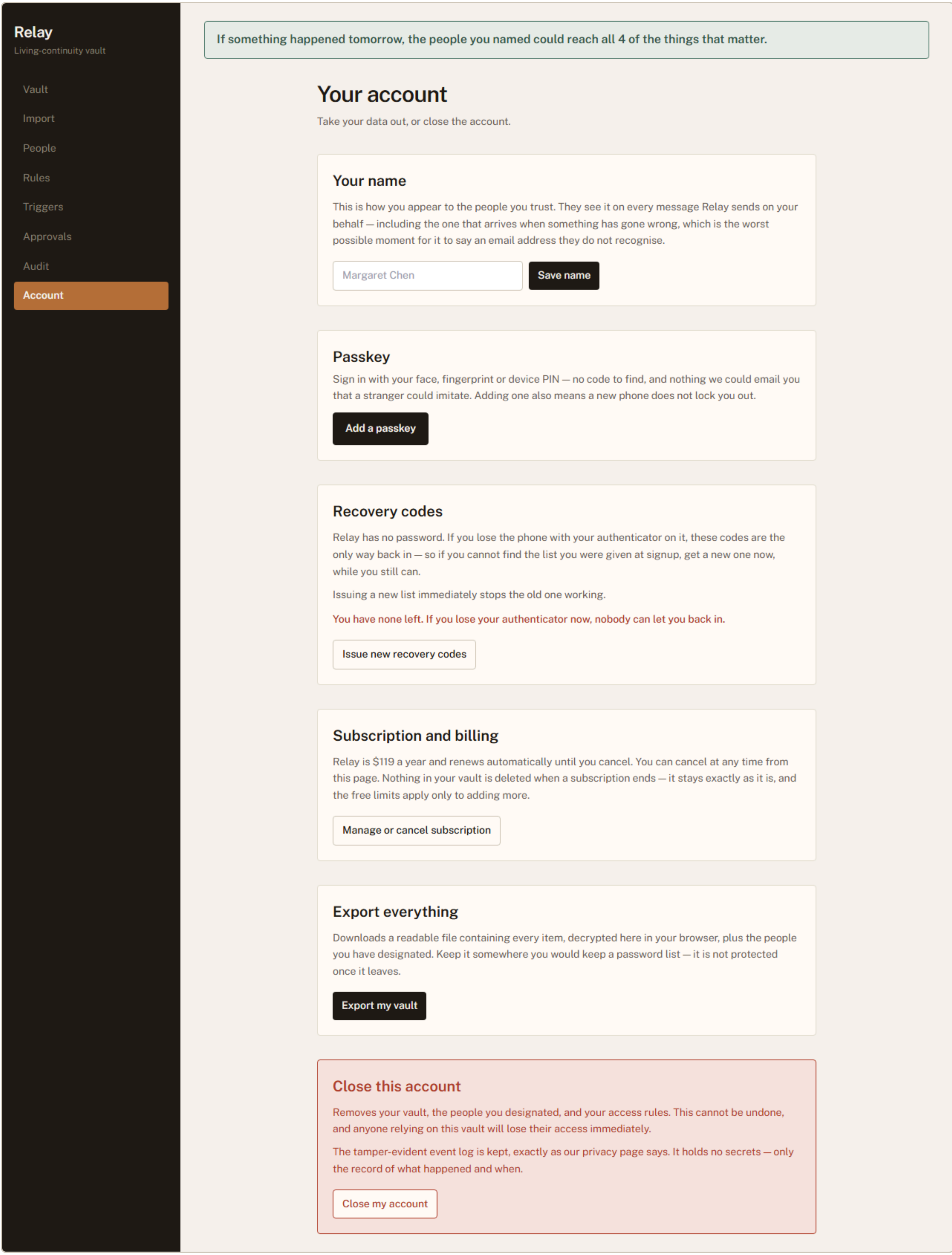
The summary answers the questions a person actually has. The table beneath is the proof that the summary is not just a nice sentence.

2.7 — Your account

You · the Account screen

Five things worth doing once, and one you may never need.

- **Your name.** This is how you appear to everyone you trust. Set it. An emergency message that says `someone@gmail.com` instead of "Margaret" is the worst possible moment for your family to wonder whether the message is real.
- **Passkey.** Your face, fingerprint or device PIN. Nothing to remember and nothing anyone can email you that a stranger could imitate.
- **Recovery codes.** Relay has no password. If you lose the phone with your authenticator on it, these are the only way back. The page tells you **how many you have left** — they are used up one per use, and running out quietly is the failure worth avoiding. Issue a fresh list any time; doing so stops the old one working.
- **Export everything.** A readable file of every item, decrypted in your browser. Your data is yours and leaving is not punished.
- **Subscription.** Cancel any time. Nothing in your vault is deleted when a subscription ends — the free limits apply only to adding more.
- **Close this account.** Removes the vault, the people and the rules. Anyone relying on it loses access immediately, and this cannot be undone.



Leaving is a first-class path, not a support ticket — export first, then close. The recovery line changes colour as the sheet runs down, because “1 left” in the same grey as everything else is a fact nobody acts on.

PART 3

For the people you name

Hand this part to them. It is written to be read by someone who has just been asked to do something they did not sign up for.

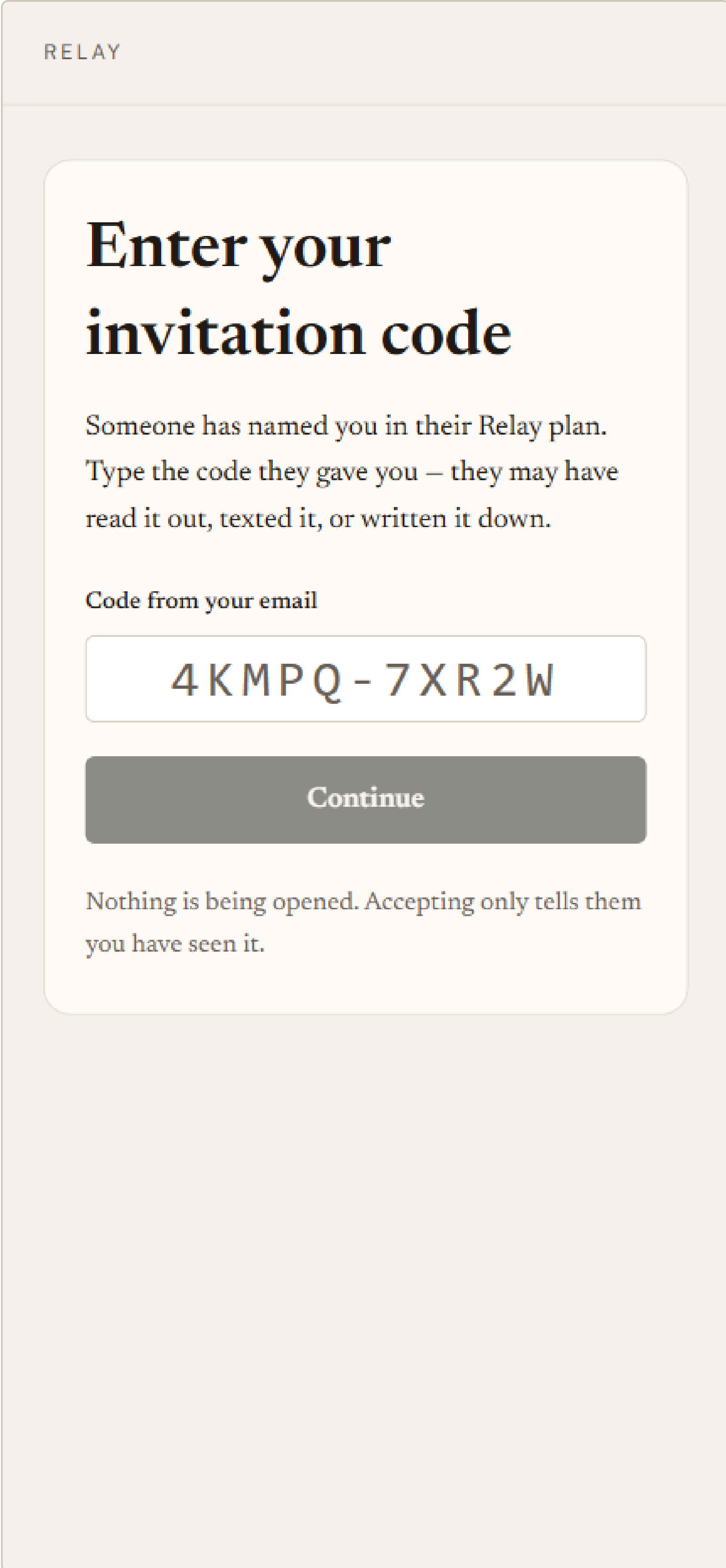
3.1 — Someone has named you. What now?

Your person · the Accept screen

> **Why you are being asked to do anything at all, in advance.** The alternative is that the first time you hear from Relay is during an emergency, in an email, asking you to make a decision about someone you love while holding a code you have never seen before. Accepting now — on a calm Tuesday — means that on the bad day you simply sign in as yourself. There is nothing to intercept, because nothing is sent.

How it works. The person who named you gives you a short code. They choose how: read out on a call, texted, written down, handed over. You type it in, and you have an account. It is free, it holds nothing of yours, and it exists so you can be recognised later.

> **Accepting does not open anything.** It does not give you access to their vault, and it does not tell them anything except that you have seen it. If you would rather not be part of this, the honest thing is to say so — and there is a control for stepping down at any time.



Typing a short code rather than clicking a link. That is deliberate: Relay never sends a link that signs you in, so a message with one in it is not from us.

3.2 — Standing by

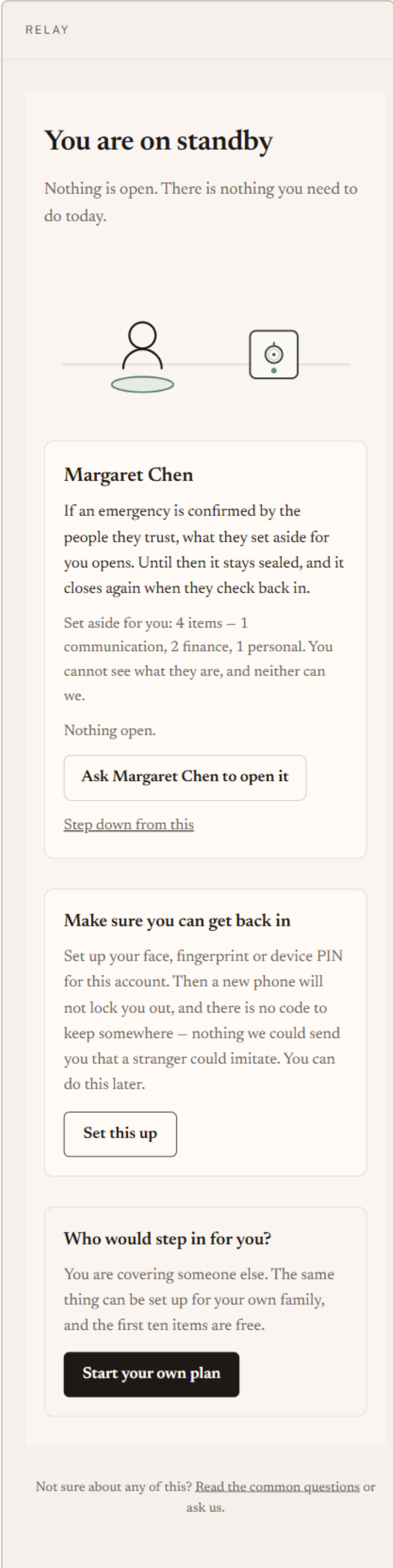
Your person · their Standby screen

Most of the time this screen says the most valuable thing it can say: **nothing is open, and there is nothing you need to do today.** It shows who you are standing by for, what would happen if an emergency were confirmed, and — if you are a recipient — how much has been set aside for you, as counts and categories. Never titles. Never contents.

It also offers to set up a passkey. Worth doing: it is what lets you get back in on a new phone without anyone having to reissue anything, and it means there is no code to keep track of.

You can stand by for more than one person. Both parents, a parent and a neighbour, a spouse who named you and a friend who did too — each appears as its own card with its own four words, its own way to ask, and its own way to step down. They are genuinely separate: stepping down from one does not touch the others, and nothing you are told about one person is visible on another's card. You can also have a vault of your own on the same account — being the person somebody relies on and having your own plan are not alternatives.

If something is set to open later. The person who named you may have staged part of it deliberately — the urgent things immediately, the rest only if they are still unreachable a week on. Those appear on your list from the start with the date they open, so a gap on the day is a plan working as written rather than something broken.



Standing by. **Step down from this** is always available — being named is not a trap, and someone who quietly stopped agreeing is worse than useless in an emergency.

3.2a — What Relay gives you, and what it does not

Your person · the first screen after access opens

The first time access opens for you, before you see anything, Relay says plainly what this is: the owner chose to share these items with you, and that is all it is. Relay does not make you an executor, an agent or a representative. The companies behind those accounts have agreed to nothing, and using someone else's credentials may breach that account's terms whatever your reason.

If the person who named you has died, the one with authority is their executor or personal representative — speak to them first. You will be asked to acknowledge this once, and the acknowledgement is written to the owner's record along with everything else.

> **Why we say it rather than leave it implied.** A product that hands over credentials silently is doing something different from one that hands them over while naming the limits. Most people reading it are a daughter with her mother's permission and have nothing to worry about; the point is that Relay should not imply an authority it cannot give anybody.

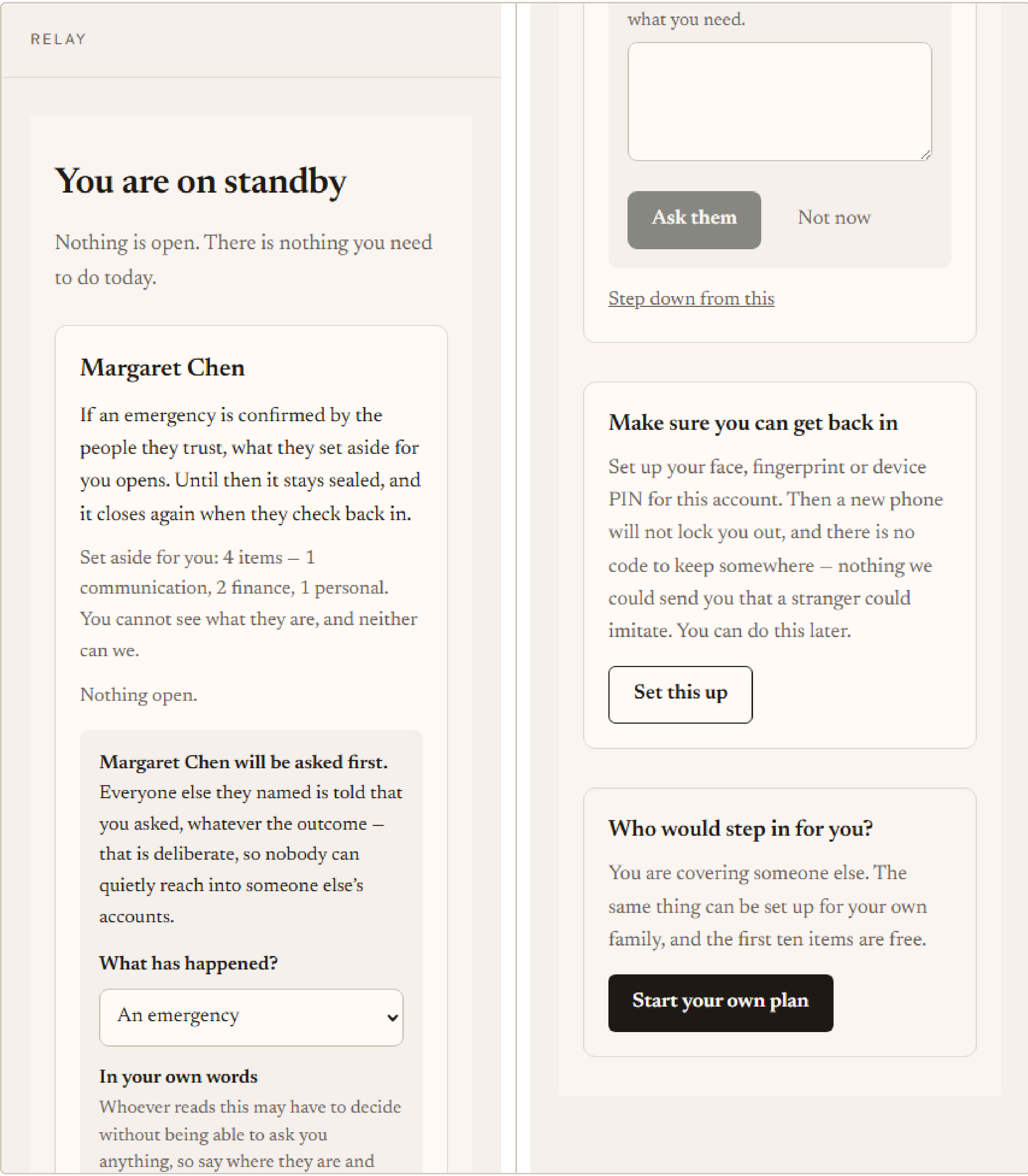
3.3 — Asking them to open it

Your person · their Standby screen

> **Why this exists.** The other paths all wait for something: for you to have anticipated the emergency, or for a check-in interval measured in weeks to run out. The commonest real case is neither — somebody is in hospital *now* and the person who would help needs to ask.

Next to "nothing is open" there is a control to ask. It says plainly, before the form is even shown, what asking costs: **you are asked first**, and **everyone else you named is told that a request was made**, whatever the outcome. That is deliberate rather than a side effect — it makes a quiet, covert attempt at somebody's accounts impossible.

You then have a window to answer. If you cannot, the people you chose to confirm an emergency are asked instead — so it does not depend on you being reachable, which is the entire point. Nobody can wear you down with it either: three requests in twenty-four hours is the limit.



One tall screen, laid out as two columns — read the left side, then the right. Asking. What it costs is said before the form, not discovered afterwards.

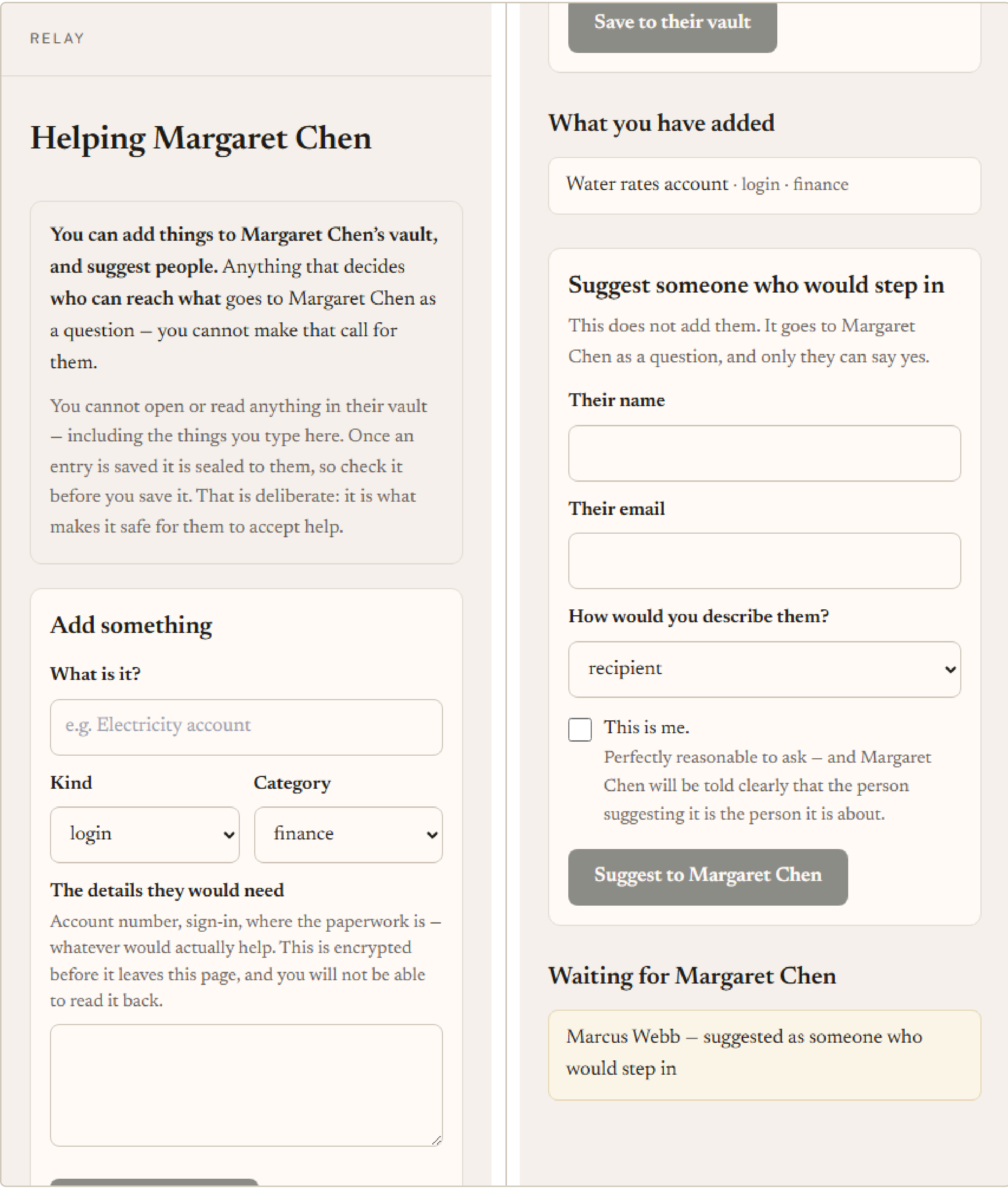
3.4 — If they asked you to help set it up

Your person · their Helping screen

> **Why this exists.** The person who most needs a plan like this is often the least likely to do the typing. The realistic alternative is that you sit down and log in *as them*, which quietly destroys every guarantee in this guide at once. This is the same help, done in a way that leaves the guarantees standing.

What you can do. Add things to their vault — the account numbers, the sign-ins, where the paperwork is — and suggest people who should be able to reach them.

What you cannot do, and this is the point. You cannot open or read anything in their vault, *including what you type yourself*: an entry is sealed to them the moment you save it, so check it before you save. You cannot decide who reaches what — every such suggestion goes to them as a question. You cannot touch their triggers, and you cannot add yourself to anything. If you think you *should* be on their plan, you can suggest exactly that, and they will be told plainly that the person suggesting it is the person it is about.



One tall screen, laid out as two columns — read the left side, then the right. The helper's screen. What you can do and what you can never do sit above the tools, so you never have to find the edge by hitting it.

3.5 — The phone call

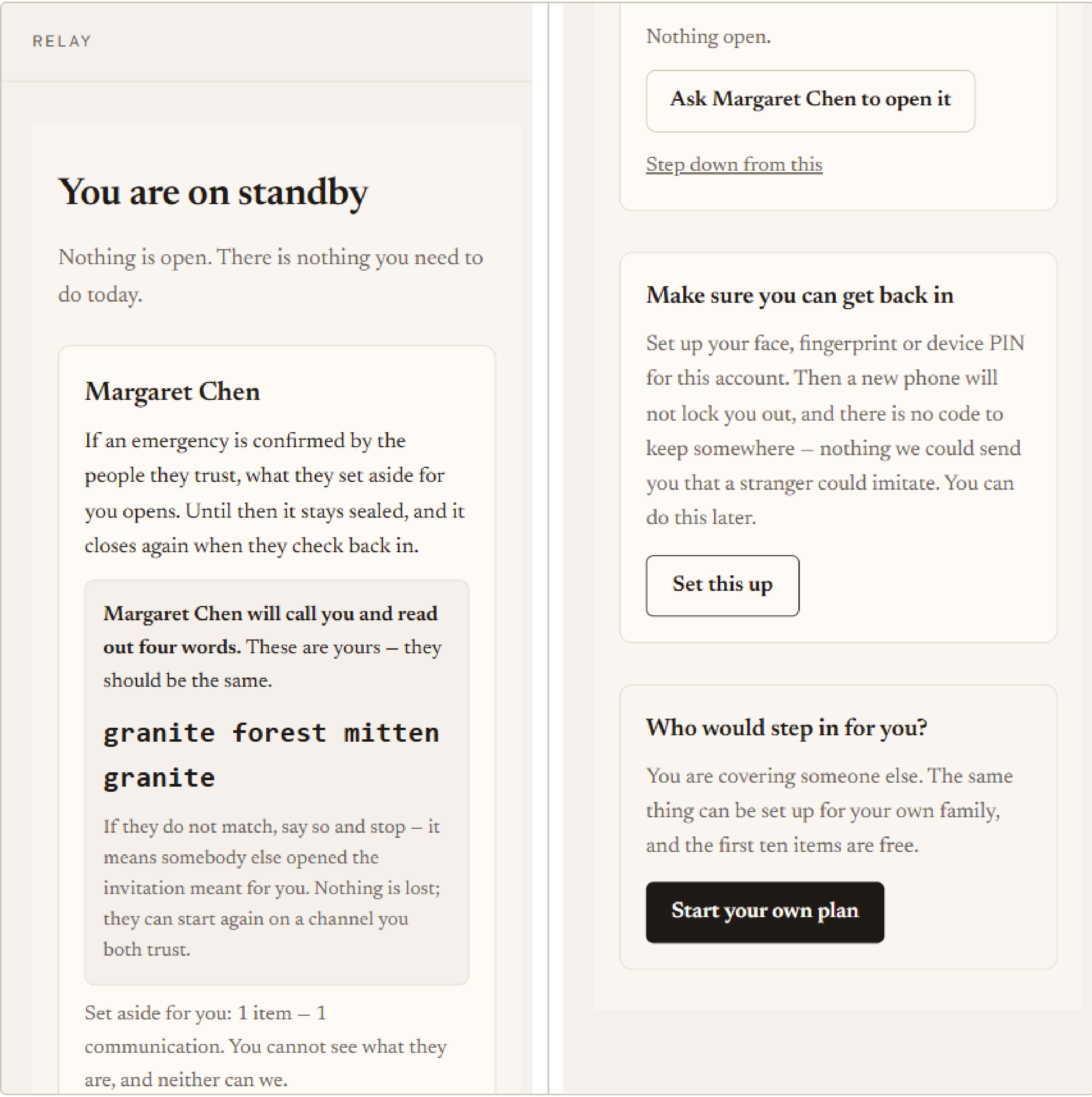
Both of you · two minutes, once

> **Why this exists.** Between the moment a code is sent and the moment it is used, it is a secret sitting in a message. If somebody else got hold of it and accepted in your place, they would look — from every angle the

> software has — exactly like you. This call is the only thing that can tell the difference, and it works for one reason: it happens over a channel an impostor cannot reach.

After you accept, **four words** appear on your screen. The person who named you has the same four on theirs. They ring you and **read theirs out**; you say whether yours match.

If they match, they mark you verified and your answer starts counting — until then it would not open anything. **If they do not match, say so and stop.** It means somebody else opened the invitation meant for you. Nothing is lost: they can cancel it and start again on a channel you both trust.



Your side of the call. The words are not a password — they are a comparison, and they are worth nothing to anybody who is not on the phone.

PART 4

The day it matters

What actually happens, in order, and who is asked what.

4.1 — Something starts it

Either you initiated a trigger yourself, or you stopped checking in for longer than your interval and Relay began asking. The trigger moves from **ARMED** to **PENDING**. Nothing has opened.

4.2 — Your verifiers are asked one question

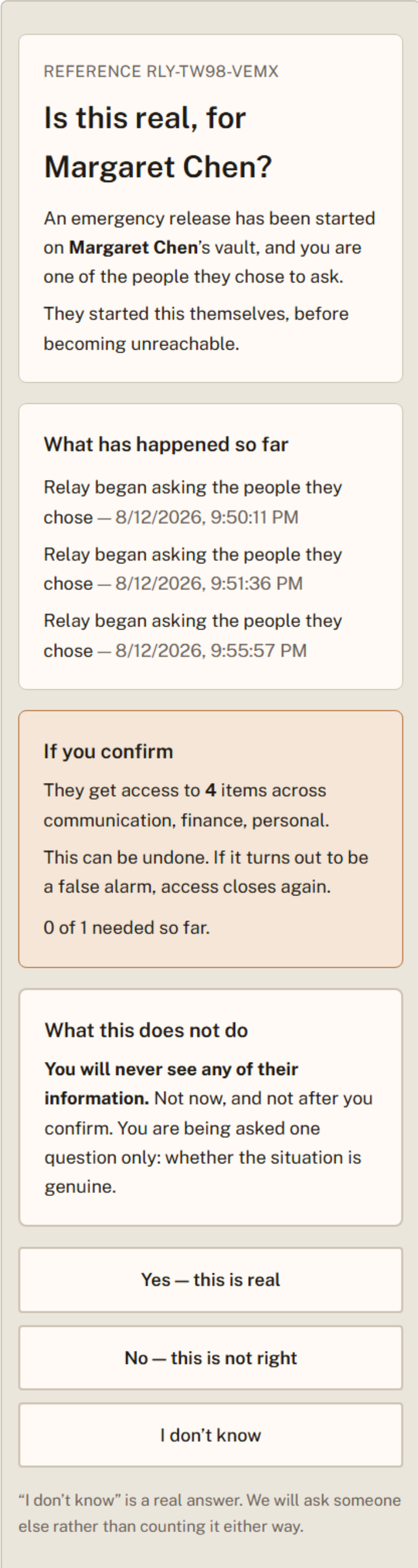
Your verifiers · the decision screen

> **Why a question and not a notification.** A notification that fires automatically is a system that can be gamed by waiting. A person who knows you, answering "is this real?", cannot be.

Each verified verifier is contacted. What they receive depends on how they are set up, and only one case involves anything secret:

IF THEY...	THEY RECEIVE
have a passkey or an authenticator	A message telling them to sign in. **No code, nothing to intercept.**
are verified but have no way to sign in	A single-use code that expires in 72 hours. They need it; nobody else does.
were named but never verified	A message saying plainly that their answer would not count yet. Better than letting someone believe they helped.

They are shown **how much** is at stake and **what kind** of thing it is, so they can judge whether the request is proportionate. They are never shown a title and never shown contents. They can answer three ways — **yes**, **no**, or **I don't know** — and "no" is offered with exactly the same prominence as "yes".



The question itself. It names whose vault it is, says why it is being asked now, shows how much is at stake and never what — and offers all three answers at the same weight, because a page that leans on "yes" produces more of them.

4.3 — You are told, immediately

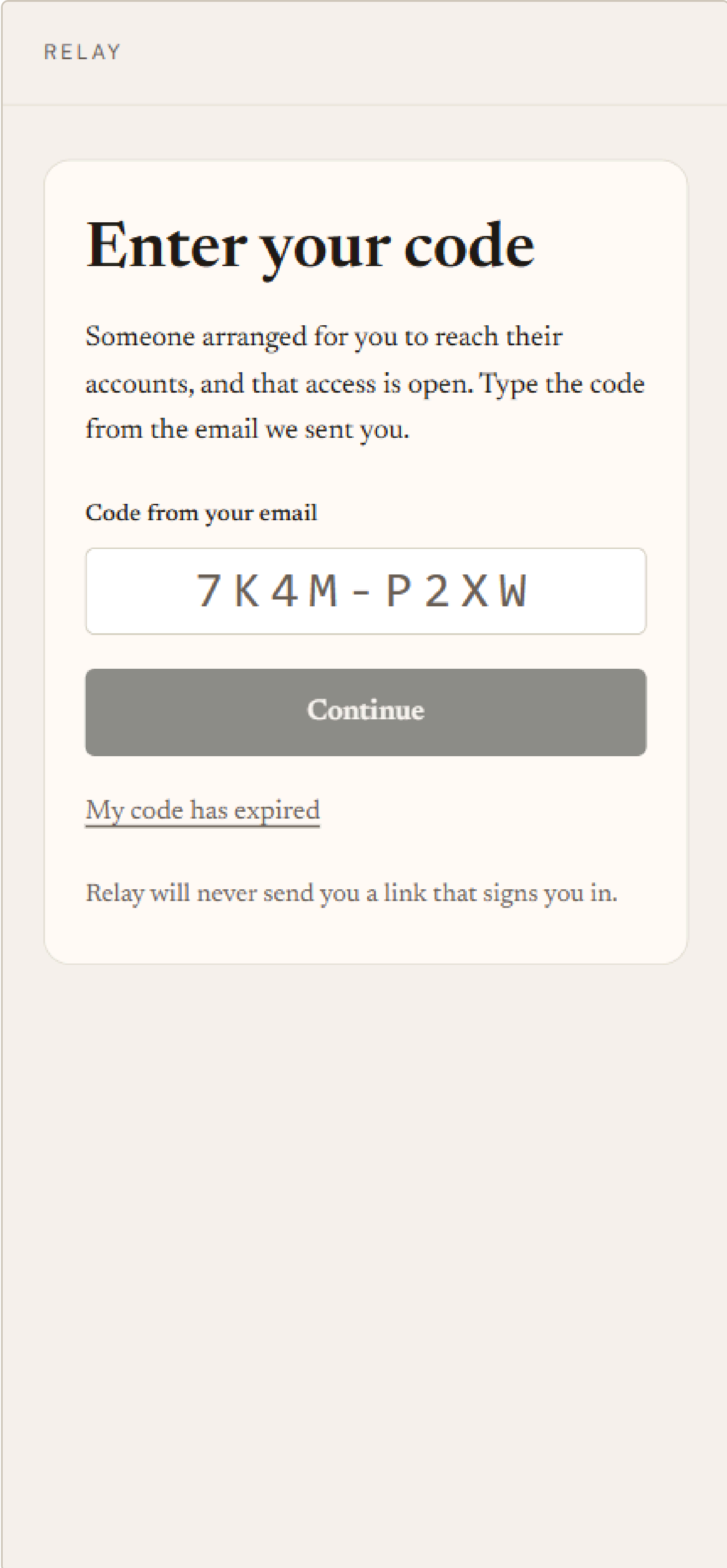
The moment enough people agree, you are told on every channel Relay has for you — and the access you arranged opens. **There is no waiting period, and the product no longer implies one.**

> **What protects you is not a delay — it is that you can undo it.** An earlier version of this message said release would complete “when the grace window elapses” and invited you to “check in now to cancel”, which was a race you would lose: for everything Relay offers today there is no waiting period at all. Checking in afterwards closes it immediately. That is the real guarantee, and unlike a countdown it does not depend on you being awake at the right moment.
>
> The one exception is the permanent handover, which waits three days precisely *because* it cannot be undone — and that is not available to customers yet. See Part 6.

4.4 — Access opens

Your recipients · their screen

Only now does anything open, and only what your rules assigned. Someone who accepted a standby account signs in as themselves; someone who never accepted receives a single-use code that lasts 24 hours. In both cases, decryption happens in their browser — Relay itself still cannot read the items.



The recipient's way in when they never accepted a standby account. **My code has expired** re-sends to the address already on file — never to one typed here.

4.5 — It closes again

You check in. Every reversible grant closes, tokens stop working, and the whole episode becomes a paragraph on your audit screen. Nothing needs to be undone by hand.

4.6 — And if you never come back

Your family · the question they will actually ask

> **Why this needs saying out loud.** Everything above is written around your return, because that is the common case and the one other products handle badly. But the case a family actually worries about is the other one, and a continuity product that does not answer it plainly is asking to be trusted on the strength of an omission.

What was opened stays open. Access closes when you check in — and only when you check in. If you never do, it does not lapse, expire or quietly withdraw. The people you chose keep what you gave them for as long as they need it. Nobody else can close it on your behalf: not your other contacts, not us.

What was not opened stays shut. Only the rules written for the trigger that fired are in force. An item nobody was scoped to still has no route to anybody, and no further release happens on its own — if a second situation arises, the people you named have to agree to that one too.

> **This is not a will, and it does not become one.** What your family gets is continued access to accounts and instructions — enough to keep a household running, pay what must be paid, and reach the people who need reaching. It transfers nothing, settles nothing and proves nothing to a bank, a registry or a court. The permanent handover that would speak to any of that is not offered today (Part 6). Whoever tells you what a will and a power of attorney should say is still the person to ask.

PART 5

When something goes wrong

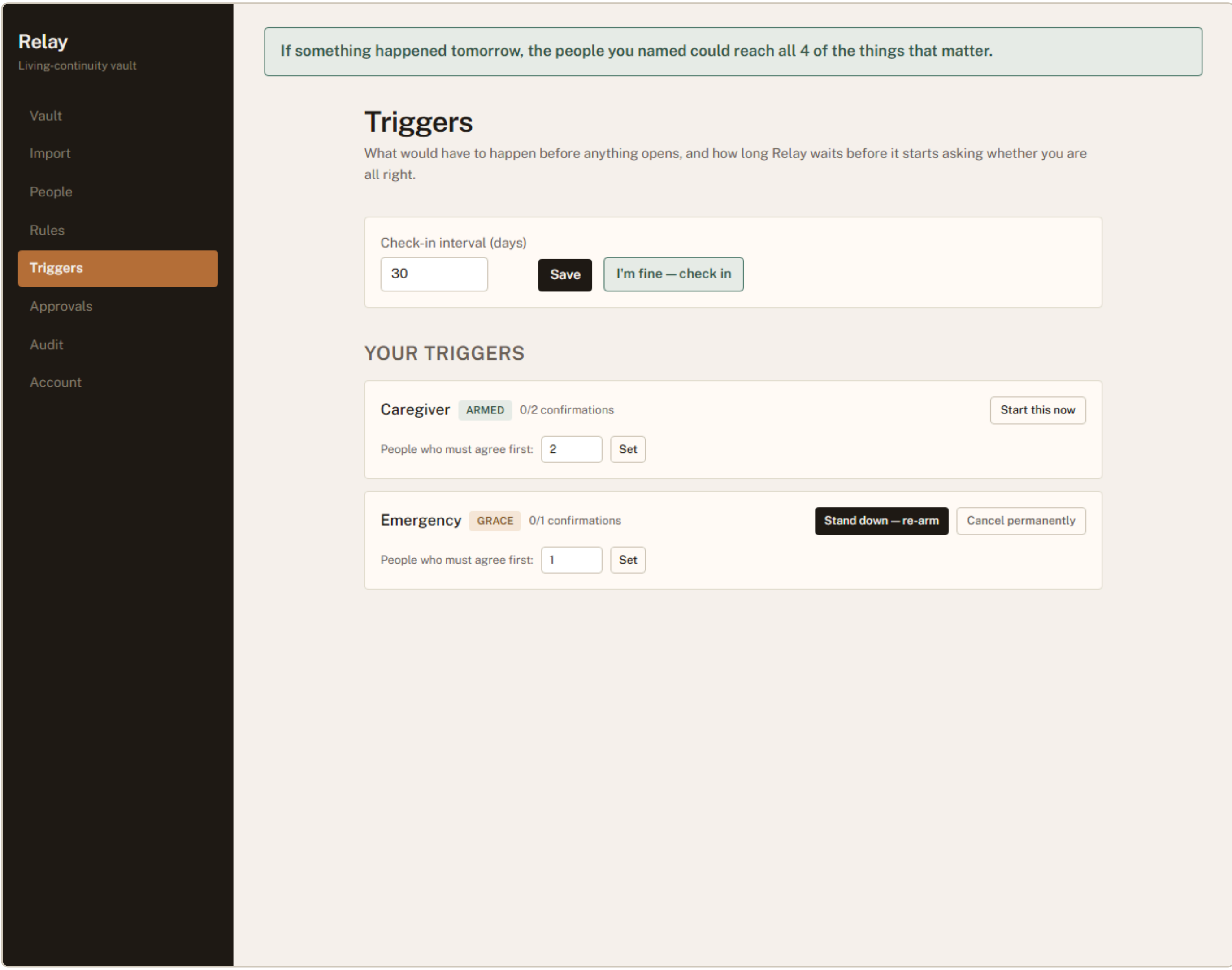
The paths that matter most are the ones nobody rehearses.

5.1 — It was a false alarm

You · the Triggers screen

Stand down — re-arm stops a release in progress or closes one that has already opened, and puts the trigger back to armed and ready. This is the control you want almost every time.

Cancel permanently retires the trigger for good. It is deliberately separated and asks for confirmation, because someone stopping a false alarm at speed must not retire their whole plan by reaching for the innocuous-looking word on the screen.



A release in flight. Both ways to stop it are here, and they are deliberately not equal in weight.

5.2 — You lost your phone

You · **Get back in**, from the sign-in screen

> **Why this is the case to plan for.** Relay has no password, so the authenticator on your phone is how you prove who you are. Over the horizon this product is meant to cover — years, not months — that phone will be replaced, lost or broken at least once. This is not the unlikely path; it is the expected one.

Lost your authenticator? on the sign-in screen takes you to **Get back in**. You give your email address and *one* of the recovery codes you saved when you created the vault. Each code works once. You then set up an authenticator again — on the new phone — and everything else is exactly as you left it.

> **Nothing in your vault is touched by this.** Recovery replaces how you sign in. It does not decrypt anything, it does not open anything for anybody, and it does not disturb your people, your rules or your triggers.

> **If you have no codes left, nobody can let you back in — including us.** That is the same encryption promise working in the direction that hurts. The Account screen shows how many you have left and colours the line as it runs down; issue a fresh list before it does. A new list stops the old one working, so keep only the newest.

If you have already lost the phone *and* the codes, your vault cannot be opened by you. It can still be opened by the people you named, in the way it was always going to be: they confirm an emergency and what you set aside for them opens. That is worth knowing before it happens rather than after.

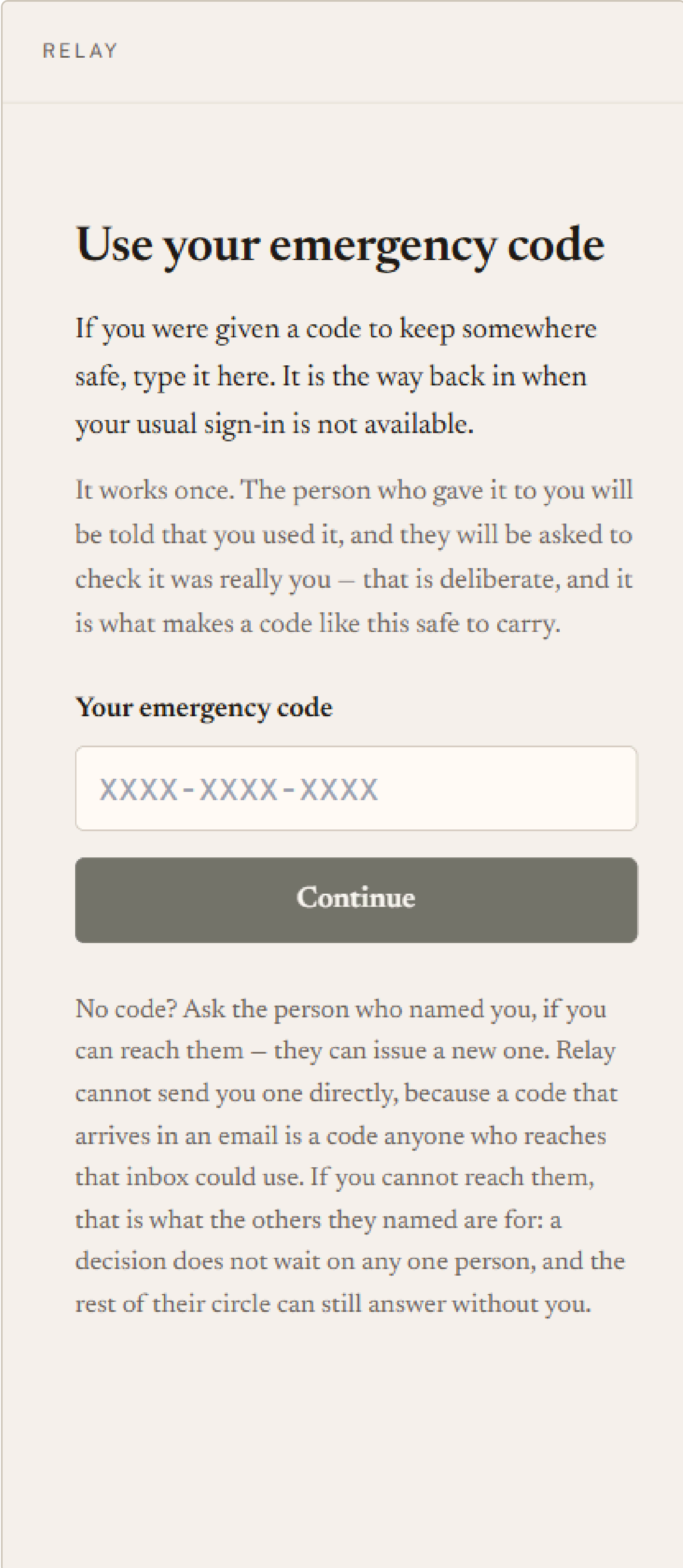
5.3 — Someone else lost their phone

Your person · the Emergency code screen

> **Why this exists.** Not everyone owns a smartphone, and everyone eventually loses one. Without this, the seventy-year-old you most want to include is excluded by their own technology, and anyone whose authenticator is at the bottom of a river has to reach you — when you may be exactly the person who cannot be reached.

You can issue anyone an emergency code, in calm, to keep somewhere safe. It works once. When it is used, you are told, and you are asked to check it was really them.

> **Issue these in advance, not during the emergency.** A code you would have to issue while unconscious is not a fallback. The banner will tell you when your plan depends on somebody who has no way back in.



The way back in when the usual sign-in is gone.

5.4 — The code never arrived, or ran out

Your person · the code screen

Both the access screen and the confirm screen carry **“my code has expired, or never arrived”**. It sends again — to the address already on file, never to one typed in, so it cannot be used to redirect anything at somebody else. What arrives depends on how that person is set up: a reminder to sign in if they have a passkey, a fresh code if they do not.

This matters most for the people confirming an emergency, because one of them being stuck holds up everybody else. If they still cannot get in, the others who were asked can still answer.

5.5 — Somebody cannot use an account at all

You · the People screen

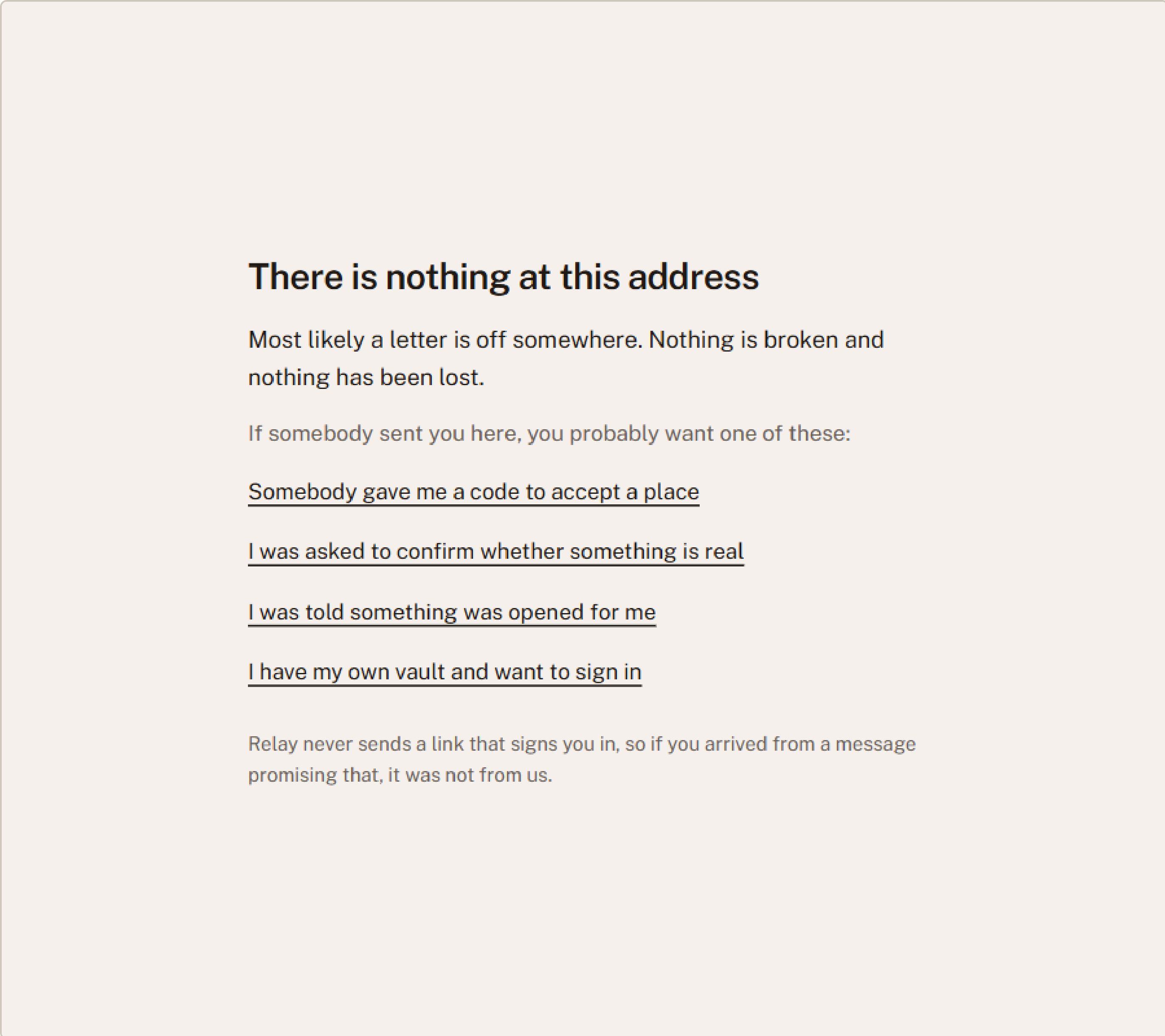
Some people will never accept — no smartphone, no interest, no email they check. Marking them **emergency code only** tells Relay that this is deliberate, so it stops asking you to chase them. It is honest rather than quiet: it also says clearly that they will never count towards your plan working, and the banner arithmetic gets *louder*, not softer.

5.6 — A page will not load, or the address is wrong

Anyone

If you land somewhere that does not exist — a letter off in an address read out over the phone — you get a page that says so and points at the four places you were probably trying to reach. If something breaks instead, the page tells you the one thing that matters: **nothing has been lost and nothing has been opened.** A page failing to load is not something changing.

Either way we are told automatically, so it does not depend on anybody reporting it. What reaches us is a reference number and the address — never anything you typed.



Written for somebody who mistyped an address in a hurry, not for an engineer.

5.7 — Somebody wants out

Your person · their Standby screen

Step down from this removes them, emails you, and recalculates your plan. Someone who no longer wants the responsibility is not a safe person to depend on, so making this easy is a safety feature rather than a courtesy.

The message distinguishes two things that look identical on a roster and are not. **"I am stepping down"** is a decision to respect. **"I do not know this person"** usually means your invitation reached the wrong address, and the right next step is to check the address before sending another — an invitation sitting in a stranger's inbox is exactly what the phone call afterwards exists to catch.

5.8 — You want out

You · the Account screen

Export everything first — it is a readable file, decrypted in your browser. Then close the account. Everyone relying on it loses access immediately. The tamper-evident event log is kept, as the privacy page says: it holds no secrets, only the record of what happened and when.

PART 6

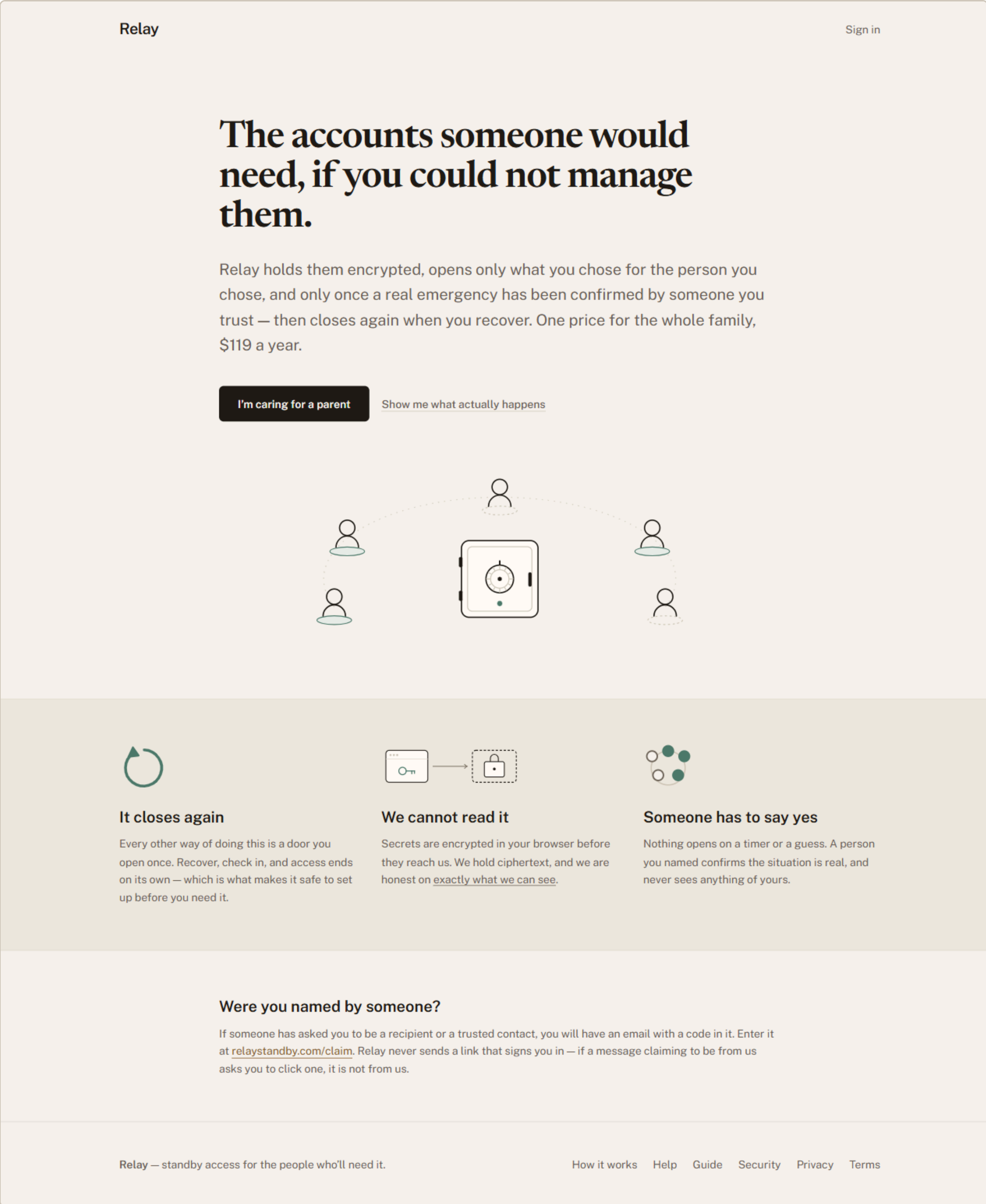
What Relay will not do

Stated plainly, because a product that overstates itself in this category is dangerous rather than merely disappointing.

- **It will not open on its own.** Silence never resolves towards open. If nobody confirms, nothing happens — which is the correct failure, and it means a plan whose people cannot be reached is a plan that does nothing.
- **It will not decide anything for your family.** It carries a decision your people make. It does not make one.
- **It cannot read your items, and cannot recover them for you.** The encryption that keeps them from us keeps them from us in every circumstance.
- **It will not make an unverified person count.** Naming someone is not verifying them. The phone call is not optional, and no amount of setup substitutes for it.
- **It does not do estates, and it is not going to.** A permanent handover was designed and built, and it was then withdrawn: as of August 2026 it is not offered, not scheduled, and not waiting on anything. Everything you can choose is reversible. Relay is not a will, gives nobody legal authority, and will not settle an estate or replace advice from somebody qualified to give it. If an owner never comes back, what was opened stays open — that is described in §4.6, and it is access, not inheritance.
- **It cannot help someone who has neither accepted nor been given a code.** That person is excluded by design, the product says so plainly rather than showing a hopeful amber light, and the fix is always the same: issue them a code while everything is calm.

The public pages

The landing page explains the product to someone who has never heard of it. The Terms and the Privacy page are written to be read — including the section addressed to people who did not sign up and were merely named by someone else, which is the population least served by ordinary legal boilerplate.



relaystandby.com — the circle standing by around a closed vault, which is the whole product in one picture. Nothing is joined to the vault, because at rest nothing is.

What actually happens is the page to send someone who says they do not understand it. It tells the story in the order a family lives it, from the day nothing is wrong through to the day somebody checks back in and it all closes again — and it is the only page that shows the handoff the product is named after. The line behind what is being passed is solid; the line ahead of it is dotted, because it has not arrived and can still be called back.

← Relay for caregivers

What actually happens

Most explanations of this kind of product describe features. Here is the sequence instead, in the order a family lives it.

BEFORE ANYTHING HAPPENS

Margaret sets it up — or her daughter does, with her permission

The accounts that matter go in: her email, the bank, the insurer, the pharmacy. Relay works out which ones unlock the others — her email resets almost everything, so it is the one that matters most. She names Sarah as the person who can step in, and her GP as someone who can confirm a real emergency. Nothing is open. Nothing is shared.

TUESDAY AFTERNOON

The call comes

Margaret is in hospital and will not be managing anything for a while. Sarah needs the pharmacy account, the insurer, and eventually the bank — and has none of it.

WITHIN MINUTES

Sarah asks, and Margaret is asked first

Sarah requests access. Relay does not ask a stranger to adjudicate — it asks Margaret, in case she can simply say yes. She cannot answer, so after a short window it moves on.

THE SAME AFTERNOON

The GP confirms it is real

He gets one question: is this genuine? He is never shown anything of Margaret's — not then, and not after. He answers yes, and that is the whole of his involvement.

IMMEDIATELY AFTER

Only what Margaret chose opens

Sarah gets exactly the items Margaret assigned to her, most consequential first, so she is not reading a list at the worst moment of her month. Everything she opens is recorded. Everything she does not open is recorded too.

SIX WEEKS LATER

Margaret comes home, and it closes

She checks in. Sarah's access ends the same minute — no awkward conversation, nothing to ask for back. Sarah is told what happened and thanked, and Margaret gets a record of exactly what was opened while she was away. The vault is armed again, ready for next time.

The last step is the one nothing else does. Every other way of doing this — a shared note, a deputy, a legacy contact — is a door you open once. Relay is the only one that closes again on its own, which is what makes it safe to set up before you need it.

What people use it for

A hospital stay

The one this is built for. Bills keep arriving, prescriptions need refilling, and the person who normally handles it is on a ward. Access opens for as long as it is needed and ends when they are home.

Caring for a parent whose memory is going

Not a single event but a slope. You need more over time, they stay in control for as long as they can, and every step is recorded so no sibling has to take anyone's word for anything.

Travel, surgery, or anything with a date on it

Two weeks somewhere with bad signal, or a procedure with a recovery period. Give someone what they would need if you were unreachable, and take it back when you are not.

Relay is not a will and does not handle inheritance. If that is what you need, an estate attorney is the right call — this is about the years before that.

How it compares

These are the four things people actually choose between. We have included the rows we lose, because a comparison where the newcomer wins everything is not worth reading.

	Relay $119/year	Everplans The organizer · $99.99/year	Bitwarden Emergency Access The password manager · Premium only	Apple / Google legacy features The phone · free	A shared note or password list What most families do · free
Works while they are alive but cannot manage things A stroke, a long hospital stay, dementia. Apple requires a death certificate before a legacy contact can request access.	●	●	●	—	●
Someone has to confirm the situation is real Bitwarden uses a waiting period you set (1 hour to 7 days) — if nobody declines, access opens on a timer rather than on a person confirming.	●	—	◐	—	—
Access can be taken back afterwards They recover, they check in, and what opened closes again on its own.	●	—	—	—	—
Each person sees only what you chose for them Rather than the whole vault, or the whole account, or the whole notebook.	●	◐	—	—	—
Covers accounts across everything they use Not just one company's ecosystem, and not just passwords.	●	●	◐	—	●
A record of who opened what, and when	●	?	?	—	—
Guided planning: templates, checklists, what to gather Everplans is genuinely better at this. If what you want is help thinking it through, start there.	—	●	—	—	—
Already set up, nothing new to buy	—	—	◐	●	●
Years of track record behind it Relay is new. Everyone else in this table has been doing it longer, and that is a real reason to choose them.	—	●	●	●	?

● yes ◐ partly — not offered ? not published by the vendor

Checked against vendor documentation on 8 August 2026. Where a company does not publish whether it does something, we say so rather than guessing. If you believe a cell is wrong, tell us and we will correct it — these are their products, not ours.

One vault, the whole family, $119 a year.

See Relay for caregivers

relaystandby.com/how-it-works

What protects your vault answers the question everybody actually has, which is not about cryptography: can these people read my mother's passwords? The two drawings at the top say the answer before the words do. In the first, the key is on your device and the space where a second one would sit on our side is empty — that emptiness is the whole security claim. In the second, an envelope carries four characters you type in yourself, and no link and no key travel with it, which is why a message from Relay never asks you to click anything.

← Relay for caregivers

What protects your vault

You are considering putting a parent's bank login into a website you had not heard of last week. These are the questions that deserve straight answers.

Can you read my mother's passwords?

No. Every secret is encrypted in your browser before it is sent, with a key we never receive in usable form. Our servers hold ciphertext and a copy of that key wrapped by AWS KMS. We can prove we hold your data; we cannot show you what is in it.

What can you read, then?

The labels. The item title, the service name, the web address, the category, and who you have designated. So we can tell that you store a Chase account — we cannot tell you anything about it. If the existence of an account is itself sensitive, do not label it accurately.

What happens if you get breached?

An attacker with our database gets ciphertext and wrapped keys, not credentials. Unwrapping requires AWS KMS to authorise it for an authenticated session, which a stolen database does not provide.

What happens if Relay disappears?

You can export everything, decrypted in your browser, from your account page at any time — not on request, and not only if we are still around to answer. Keep that file the way you would keep a password list.

Can someone trick you into opening my vault?

Releasing requires the trigger you configured AND confirmation from the people you named. Relay never sends a link that signs anyone in — every message asks for a code typed at our address — so a convincing email cannot, by itself, open anything.

What if I lose my phone?

You get recovery codes when you create the vault. One of them enrols a new authenticator. Losing the phone costs you your sign-in, not your data — but lose the codes too and nobody can let you in, including us.

> **One thing we will not claim.** Relay is early-stage software with no paying customers yet. The engineering above is real and you can inspect it, but a young product is a young product — please do not make this the only place something important is written down. Our terms say the same thing.

How it is built

For readers who want the mechanism rather than the reassurance.

A release does not expire on its own

Access opens when the conditions the owner set are met — including their check-ins stopping — and closes when they check in or stand it down. Nothing closes it automatically. If an owner never returns, what was opened stays open to the people they named, and what was never scoped to anybody stays shut. Relay does not offer estate or inheritance services and confers no legal authority on anyone; recipients are told so, once, before they see anything, and the acknowledgement is written to the owner's audit log.

Client-side envelope encryption

A per-item AES-GCM-256 data key is generated in the browser via SubtleCrypto, used to encrypt the secret, then wrapped by an AWS KMS customer master key. The server stores ciphertext plus the wrapped key and never handles the plaintext data key.

A release state machine, not a share button

ARMED → PENDING → GRACE → RELEASED, with exactly seven permitted transitions. Each one is a compare-and-set against a strongly-consistent store, so an owner, a verifier and the scheduler acting at the same moment cannot double-release. Exhausting a retry always lands back in ARMED — the safe state is the default, not the exception.

Reversibility as a property of the trigger

Whether a release can be undone is derived from the trigger type rather than a flag someone could set wrongly. Emergencies reverse; estate handoffs are permanent by construction.

Hash-chained audit log

Every access, grant and release is an append-only entry whose hash includes the previous entry's. Editing history is detectable, and the chain is verifiable in your own browser rather than on our word. A failed audit write blocks the operation it was recording.

Zero-knowledge boundary for the ranking

The component that works out which credentials unlock the others reads labels only. It is structurally prevented from decrypting anything, so the analysis that makes the product useful cannot become the thing that exposes you.

Aurora DSQL, active-active across regions

The correctness invariant is owned by the database rather than reconstructed in application code, and the data survives the loss of a region.

> Relay won **Most Impactful** at the H0 hackathon, judged on this architecture. The build is public and open to inspection.
>
> Source code   Submission and judging   Guided demo

Still deciding? The clearest way to judge it is to see what happens.

How it works   Relay for caregivers

relaystandby.com/security